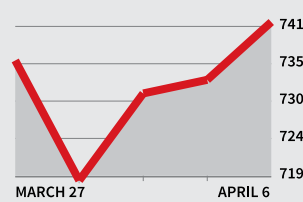


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74106.85 (+787.30)

IN FOCUS



	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	22968.25	+255.15
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.37	+0.22
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.06	-0.04
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	148303.00	+2282
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	234043.00	+6230

GOVERNANCE BOOST.

SEBI is building a collaborative framework to strengthen the Independent Directors' pipeline, says Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey **p6**



POLLSCAPE.

Matua community, second largest SC population in Bengal, feels left out after SIR exercise **p7**

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QUICKLY.

WAR IMPACT

Services PMI at 14-month low of 57.5 in March



New Delhi: The services sector in India faced the impact of the first full month of the West Asia war in March, as the Purchasing Managers' Index slipped to a 14-month low of 57.5. The worst aspect was input price inflation, which hit a 45-month high, S&P Global said. The good news is that job creation rose. The fall in the services PMI is in line with manufacturing. **p3**

TRUCE TALK

Sensex, Nifty gain for the third straight day

Mumbai: Markets staged a broad-based recovery, with the Nifty 50 closing at 22,968, up 255 points and the BSE Sensex settling at 74,107, a gain of 787 points, marking the third consecutive session of positive close — a trend, analysts say, signals a gradual easing of selling pressure. On Monday, FPIs offloaded shares worth ₹8,167.17 crore, per data on the exchanges. **p6**

Wipro bags \$1 b Olam deal, buys IT arm Mindsprint for \$375 m

TRANSFORMATIVE. To generate over \$100 m annually, translating to roughly \$1 b in 8 yrs

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Wipro has acquired Mindsprint as part of a \$1 billion-plus transformation deal with the Olam Group, seeking to lock in long-term, annuity-style revenue and deepen domain capabilities.

Analysts said this signals a shift towards large, outcome-led engagements amid slowing industry growth.

Wipro on Monday secured a multi-year strategic transformation deal with the Olam Group, a Singapore-based food and agri-business with over \$50 billion annual revenues. The eight-year engagement is expected to exceed \$1 billion in contract value, with a committed spend of \$800 million.

As part of this deal, Wipro will acquire Mindsprint, Olam Group's IT services arm, for \$375 million in an all-cash deal. The transaction is expected to be completed by June 30.

Mindsprint has a global workforce of over 3,200 employees across India, Singapore, the US, the UK, and the

Wipro's big ticket buys

Name of acquired company	Size	Date of acquisition	Area of expertise
Mindsprint	\$375 m	2026	Food and Agriculture
HARMAN Digital Transformation Solutions	\$375 m	2025	Digital engineering and ER&D
Rizing	\$540 m	2022	SAP consulting
Ampion	\$117 m	2021	Cybersecurity
Capco	\$1.45 b	2021	BFSI consulting
Edgile	\$230 m	2021	Cybersecurity

Source: Company reports

Middle East. It has strong food and agri-business domain experience, supply chain transformation capabilities and proprietary IP-driven solutions. Mindsprint's consolidated revenues for CY25 were \$135.6 million.

DOMAIN KNOWLEDGE According to sources close to the company, the acquisition gives Wipro a strong revenue visibility, with over \$100 million annually from Mindsprint, translating to roughly \$1 billion over eight years.

"With this acquisition, Wipro gets the expertise and domain knowledge of the food and agri supply chain business. Mindsprint brings the domain knowledge from

years of working with Olam, and Wipro has the scale, operational efficiency and capability to run larger operations. That is broadly the rationale behind this acquisition," the sources observed.

Alongside, other sources close to the deal said that they do not expect any personnel-related changes or disruptions due to the transaction, at the moment.

While Mindsprint started as a captive of Olam, the latter is well diversified, serving sectors such as manufacturing, life sciences, retail and CPG, BFSI and logistics.

"This acquisition signals that Wipro wants to compete on domain knowledge and AI-led transformation, not just on cost and headcount.

To keep up fuel supply, no refinery maintenance shutdown for now

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

India, which has more than 258 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) of domestic refining capacity, will keep its refineries running, postponing any maintenance shutdowns in a bid to maintain stable supplies of diesel, petrol and jet fuel.

However, Nayara Energy will go for a refinery maintenance shutdown from April 9-10 for around 35 days.

Rosneft-backed Nayara owns and operates the 20 mtpa Vadinar refinery in Gujarat. The maintenance operation could not be postponed as the exercise was already delayed.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Oil Ministry, said some units of the Indian Oil Corporation and Bharat Petroleum Corporation had postponed their maintenance shutdowns.

However, she did not specify which refineries of the two PSU oil marketing companies had postponed their maintenance.

IOC operates around 70.3 mtpa capacity, the highest in the country, while BPCL has 35.3 mtpa capacity.

Steady Q4 expected for banks on strong metrics

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Based on provisional data released by the banks so far, they are expected to report a steady fourth quarter (Q4FY26) on the back of healthy loan and deposit growth, controlled slippages and a decent rise in profit, according to analysts.

CREDIT, DEPOSIT UP

Loan growth has been sound as hardening yields in the bond market led India Inc to turn to banks for funds, going by provisional numbers shared by the banks.

Similarly, deposit growth is up, with investors preferring safety at a time when equities are taking a beating, feeling the ripple effect of the West Asia war.

For instance, HDFC Bank, India's largest private lender, reported a 14.4 per cent year-on-year rise in deposits and 12 per cent growth in gross advances. In the public sector space, Bank of Baroda posted 12 per cent growth in global deposits and a 16.23 per cent jump in global advances in Q4.

Overall, the business momentum for lenders has been healthy with advances up 4.8 per cent and deposits up 6.1 per cent sequentially, per an

Equirus report. "Credit growth in Q4 was led by gold loans, transport operators, NBFCs and traders. We expect working capital demand to have been strong in Q4," it said.

SLIPPAGES DOWN

Against the backdrop of a volatile macro environment, ICICI Securities analysts' envisaged the banking sector delivering a relatively steady quarter with healthy loan/deposits growth, improved slippages and broadly stable return on assets.

They expect FY26E loan growth of 13.8 per cent y-o-y, translating to roughly 4 per cent growth each quarter, with acceleration on the wholesale side due to bond substitution.

"The improvement in overall funding cost is likely to be calibrated, beset by pressure from bulk deposits. While NII (net interest income) growth trails loan growth, we believe the former has bottomed out and should rise to 9 per cent y-o-y (ex-one-offs) versus 2-5 per cent y-o-yearlier.

Yes Securities expects the net profit of State Bank of India and HDFC Bank to increase 7 per cent y-o-y (to ₹19,940 crore) and 5.8 per cent (to ₹18,640 crore), respectively.

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Godrej Consumer
sees 6-9% cost surge



Mumbai: Godrej Consumer Products Ltd expects a 6-9 per cent increase in input costs due to a sharp rise in crude-linked commodities, even as it guided for steady double-digit revenue growth, pointing to a balance between inflation pressures and demand resilience, according to a regulatory filing. “We do expect sustained inflation into the first half of FY27 and will address the same through a combination of pricing actions and cost efficiency programmes,” the company said. In terms of key strategic levers for FY26, the company has forayed into the expansion of the ₹1,000-crore men's facewash market via the acquisition of the ‘Muuchstac’ brand. **OUR BUREAU**

How India’s top cars stack up on CO₂ emissions ahead of CAFE-3

GEOPOLITICAL FALLOUT. Push for granular data comes amid global energy volatility post West Asia conflict

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

As the Centre moves to tighten fuel efficiency standards for passenger vehicles, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) has submitted vehicle-specific emission data to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) as part of accelerated preparations for the upcoming Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE-3) norms, scheduled to take effect next year.

The push for more granular data comes against the backdrop of global energy volatility triggered by the ongoing West Asia conflict, which has sharpened the government's focus on reducing fuel consumption and improving energy security. Sources told *businessline*

that the PMO had sought detailed information on vehicle-level fuel consumption and carbon emissions to identify high-consumption models and those delivering the lowest mileage, signalling tighter scrutiny of the automotive sector's efficiency performance ahead of the new regulatory phase.

Data submitted indicate Maruti Suzuki India's fleet shows a comparatively lower carbon footprint than several key competitors across segments.

MID-HATCHBACK
In the mid-hatchback segment, of vehicles with 1.0 l to 1.2 l engines priced between ₹5 lakh and ₹6.6 lakh, Maruti Suzuki WagonR emits 98 kg of CO₂ per 1,000 km, significantly lower than the 122 kg recorded by Tata Tiago. In premium hatchbacks

Carbon footprint				
(Emissions in kg of CO ₂ terms/1,000 km)				
Car category	Fuel guzzler	Emission	Fuel saver	Emission
Mid hatchback				
Engine size: 1 L to 1.2 L	Tata Tiago	122	Maruti Wagon R	98
Premium hatchback				
Engine size: All 1.2 L	Tata Altroz	127	Maruti Swift	106
Mid SUV				
Engine size: 1.5 L to 2 L	Scorpio	195	Maruti Victoris	113
	MG Hector	182	Maruti G. Vitara	117
			Maruti Victoris*	84
			Maruti G. Vitara*	85

*S Hybrid

(1.2 l engine, ₹6.5-₹9 lakh), Maruti Suzuki Swift (petrol) emits 106 kg of CO₂ per 1,000 km, compared with 127 kg per 1,000 km for the Tata Altroz (petrol).

A similar trend is seen in sedans (1.2 l engine, ₹6.5-₹8.5 lakh), where Maruti Suzuki Dzire (petrol) emits 98 kg per 1,000 km, while the Tata Tigor emits an estim-

ated 123 kg per 1,000 km. In mid-SUVs (1.5-2 l engine, ₹13-₹16 lakh), Maruti Suzuki's Victoris (petrol) and Grand Vitara record emissions of 113 kg and 117 kg per 1,000 km respectively, compared with Mahindra & Mahindra's Scorpio at an estimated 195 kg per 1,000 km and the MG Hector at 182 kg per 1,000 km.

Automobile retail sales hit all-time high of 2.96 crore units in FY26

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Automobile retail sales hit an all-time high of 2,96,71,064 units in FY26, a year-on-year (y-o-y) growth of 13.3 per cent, compared with 2,61,87,255 units in FY25, the Federation Of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA), said on Monday. “This is not just a number — it represents the industry approaching the 3-crore mark, a milestone that would have seemed distant just two years ago. What makes this year particularly significant is that the growth was structurally sound, underpinned by improving affordability,

widening mobility demand across urban and rural India, and a diversifying power-train mix,” CS Vigneshwar, President, FADA, said sharing latest data. Two-wheelers (2W) reclaimed their pre-Covid peak, retailing over 2.14 crore units and growing 13.40 per cent — a recovery that had been long-awaited and finally unlocked by the combination of GST-led affordability, improved rural cash flows, and a broadening product portfolio in entry-level and aspirational segments, he said.

PVs SoAR
Passenger vehicles (PVs) crossed the 47-lakh mark for the first time, growing 13 per

All India vehicle retail data for FY26			
Category	FY26	FY25	y-o-y %
Passenger vehicle	47,05,056	41,63,927	13.00
Two-wheeler	2,14,20,386	1,88,89,595	13.40
Three-wheeler	13,63,412	12,20,834	11.68
Commercial vehicle	10,60,906	9,49,406	11.74
Tractor	10,50,077	8,82,825	19.00
Total (including others)	2,96,71,064	2,61,87,255	13.3

Source: FADA Research

cent y-o-y compared with around 41.64 lakh units, supported by a rich new-model pipeline, steady urbanisation, and sustained shift towards SUVs and alternative powertrains.

Three-wheelers (3Ws) set third consecutive annual record at 11.68 per cent growth, with the electric

vehicle (EV) transition now accounting for over 60 per cent of the segment's retail. Commercial vehicles (CVs) recorded best-ever figures and surged above the 10-lakh mark for the first time at 11.74 per cent growth on infrastructure-driven freight demand and a particularly strong MCV sub-seg-

ment. FADA said tractors were the year's standout performer, crossing 10-lakh units for the first time at 18.95 per cent growth — a direct reflection of an excellent monsoon, strong rabi sowing, and improving farm economics.

In terms of monthly retail, March 2026 was a landmark month when industry retailed 26,92,449 vehicles — the highest-ever March in FADA records — posting a 25.28 per cent on-year growth compared with 21,49,116 in the corresponding month last year. “More than the headline number, what stands out is the quality of this close: it was driven by genuine retail pull rather

than channel push, backed by enquiry conversion, healthy walk-in trends, and sustained consumer engagement right through the month,” Vigneshwar said. PV sales grew by 21.48 per cent on-year to 4,40,144 units during the month as compared with 3,62,304 units in March 2025. Similarly, 2W retail sales grew by 28.68 per cent y-o-y to 19,51,006 units in March as against 15,16,150 units in the same month last year. Retail sales of 3Ws grew by 10.52 per cent y-o-y to 1,09,777 units as compared with 99,325 a year ago. CV segment grew by 15 per cent y-o-y to 1,02,536 units last month.

SC declines to stay order allowing Adani to acquire JAL, asks NCLAT to decide

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday declined to stay the implementation of the Adani group's ₹14,535-crore bid to acquire the debt-ridden Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), but provided a safeguard by restraining the firm's monitoring committee from taking any “major policy decisions” without prior nod of the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joyimalya Bagchi asked mining giant Vedanta Ltd, which is opposing the resolution plan, and Adani Enterprises Ltd to raise contentions and counter claims before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), which will start final hearing

on the row on April 10. The top court asked the NCLAT to decide the plea and the counter petition expeditiously by hearing them on an “out of turn basis” on the dispute over the acquisition of JAL by the Adani group.

“In view of the fact that the company appeals are now listed for final hearing at the NCLAT on April 10, 2026, we see no reason to interfere with the impugned order. However, having regard to the nature of the issue, we request the NCLAT to hear the appeal on an out-of-turn basis on the date fixed or immediately on the next working day if arguments do not conclude. Both sides have assured us full cooperation on the date fixed,” it ordered.

“Since the appeal is likely to be decided very soon and the interest of the appellant



has been adequately protected in the impugned order, there seems to be no necessity to issue any other direction. If the monitoring committee decides to take any major policy decision, they will take leave of the NCLAT,” the bench said. Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Vedanta Ltd, said the NCLAT itself says there were issues to be decided and their bid was the

highest. “If this (resolution) plan is implemented, then you see what the creditors get. My number is ₹17,926.21 crore. They (Adani) are paying ₹14,000-odd crore. Creditors will get more. Qua net present value and total amount, I am the highest. Creditors are willing to give Jaypee for ₹3,000 crore less,” Sibal said.

INTERIM STAGE
The committee of creditors was represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta. The Adani group was represented by senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi with a team from the legal firm Karanjawala and Co. The CJJ said the issue was at an interim stage only. The solicitor general said the difference between the two bids is ₹500 crore and, moreover, there are several other parameters.

Nykaa sees 28% revenue growth in Q4, poised for ₹10,000-cr milestone

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

FSN E-Commerce Ventures Ltd (Nykaa) expects consolidated net revenue to grow 27-29 per cent on-year in the March quarter, marking its fastest expansion in 12 quarters, driven by a rebound in fashion business and steady momentum in beauty, according to a regulatory filing. For FY26, Nykaa expects net revenue growth of around 25-27 per cent, with net sales value growth seen slightly higher in the late twenties range, indicating improving conversion trends, the company said. Based on the FY25 revenue of ₹7,949.82 crore, analysts estimate FY26 revenue in the range of ₹9,900-10,100 crore, within reach of the ₹10,000-crore milestone.



Nykaa's core beauty and personal care business has continued to deliver steady growth in the late twenties across metrics, supported by a strong omnichannel performance and faster scaling of its House of Nykaa brands. The company expanded its physical retail footprint during the quarter, adding 26 stores and integrating 11 Kiehl's outlets, taking the total store count to 313 as of March 31, 2026, marking its highest quarterly store addition to date. It remains watchful of the

evolving geopolitical situation in West Asia, though it has not reported any material impact in the quarter. Exposure to the region remains limited, contributing less than 1 per cent of overall revenue, it added.

NET SALES VALUE
For the full year FY26, net revenue growth is projected at the upper end of the mid-twenties range, indicating an acceleration over the past two years, while improved conversion metrics saw net sales value (NSV) growth outpace gross merchandise value (GMV) during the quarter. The GMV-to-NSV conversion improved meaningfully, reflecting better funnel efficiency. The company said the improved performance was led by a sharp recovery in its fashion vertical, where NSV

growth is expected in the early forties, significantly ahead of GMV growth in the late twenties, signalling better conversion and lower discounting impact. Net revenue growth in the segment is also seen accelerating to the late thirties, aided by improved platform funnel, customer acquisition, traction from its Nike partnership and sales events such as the Pink Love Sale. “This strong performance came on the back of acceleration in the fashion vertical and sustained strong performance of the beauty vertical,” the company said. Based on FY25 Beauty GMV of ₹11,775 crore and guided high-twenties growth, the segment is likely to scale to around ₹15,000-15,200 crore in FY26, implying an incremental addition of over ₹3,000 crore on-year.

SP Group gets relief on \$3.4 b debt

Bloomberg

A unit of Shapoorji Pallonji Group has secured approval from its major lenders to ease a key debt condition after falling collateral values pushed it closer to its borrowing limits, according to people familiar with the matter.

Its financing arm, Porteast Investment, will temporarily raise its loan-to-value limit to 40 per cent from 34 per cent for four months through July 15, the people said, declining to be identified because the information is private. The \$3.4 billion loan, raised last May at a steep yield of 19.75 per cent, counts large creditors such as Ares Management Corp, Cerberus Capital Management, Davidson Kempner Capital Management, Farallon Capital Management and Deutsche Bank AG. The pressure follows a de-



cline in the derived value of Tata Sons shares pledged as collateral, the people said. Tata Sons, the unlisted holding company of the Tata Group, gets much of its value from its stake in Tata Consultancy Services. Shares of TCS have slumped more than 22 per cent so far this year amid a broader selloff in software stocks, driven by concerns around AI disruption and geopolitical uncertainty, dragging down Tata Sons' valuation. Without a breather, the SP Group risked breaching debt covenant just as it needs to refin-

ance about \$2.5 billion of rupee-denominated debt at its unit Goswami Infratech due on April 30. The unit plans to raise up to \$1 billion through its first dollar-bond sale, with the rest to be refinanced through local debt issued simultaneously. The episode highlights how sensitive the construction conglomerate's financing is to movements in Tata Sons-linked equity valuations, and more broadly, how jittery credit markets have become in the wake of the Middle East conflict.

NO RESPONSE
A spokesperson for the Shapoorji Pallonji Group did not immediately respond to a request for comment, while a Deutsche Bank spokesperson declined to comment. Representatives for Ares Management, Cerberus Capital, Davidson Kempner and Farallon Capital did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Drools forays into fresh pet food with ₹180-cr investment

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Pet food company Drools said it is foraying into the fresh pet food segment and will invest ₹180 crore in advanced processing and packaging infrastructure. It has also linked a strategic collaboration with Tetra Pak to introduce fresh pet food in Tetra Recart packaging, enabling it to combine large-scale manufacturing and global packaging technology to offer a new format of pet nutrition in the Indian market.

INFLECTION POINT
India's pet food market, currently estimated at \$700-900 million, is growing at 11-16 per cent CAGR, with premium and specialised nutrition emerging as the fastest-growing segments. Fahim Sultan, Founder, Drools Pet Food Pvt Ltd,



BRANCHING OUT. The firm said it would expand the category beyond the traditional dry and wet formats

said, “India's pet food market is at an inflection point, with consumers actively seeking better, fresher, and more transparent nutrition for their pets. At Drools, we have always believed in building the category ahead of demand. Our investment and collaboration with Tetra Pak allows us to bring global advancements in food processing and packaging to India, making fresh pet food both accessible and scalable.

This is not just a product innovation — it is a step towards redefining pet nutrition in the country.”

SHELF STABILITY
The company said, with this move, it would expand the category beyond the traditional dry and wet formats. Tetra Pak's advanced retort and aseptic packaging technologies would ensure safety, shelf stability, nutrient retention and also re-

India's pet food market, currently estimated at \$700-900 million, is growing at 11-16% CAGR

move the need for cold-chain logistics, a key barrier to scaling fresh food formats in India.

BROADER SHIFT
Cassio Simões, Managing Director, South Asia Markets, Tetra Pak, added, “The evolution of pet nutrition in India reflects a broader shift towards quality, safety, and sustainability. Our collaboration with Drools demonstrates how advanced processing and packaging technologies can unlock entirely new categories by combining the benefits of fresh nutrition with convenience and scalability. We believe this innovation will play a



CS Vigneshwar, FADA President

roughly 8.2 lakh units in FY25. EVs, while still a smaller portion of the market, are growing rapidly. Their share increased to 4.25 per cent in FY26 from 2.61 per cent a year ago, equivalent to around 2.0 lakh units, up from about 1.1 lakh units in FY25.

The divergence highlights a two-speed transition. CNG is driving immediate adoption due to lower running costs and wider availability, while EVs are expanding quickly from a low base, pointing to a gradual shift towards electrification. Mass-market manufacturers are leading the CNG push.

Maruti Suzuki continues to anchor the segment with models such as WagonR, Dzire, Ertiga and Brezza, while Hyundai and Tata Motors are also seeing steady traction across entry and mid-level offerings.

In EVs, the market remains more concentrated, led by Tata Motors, with MG Motor gaining ground in urban segments. Meanwhile, petrol's share declined to 47.48 per cent in FY26 from 50.82 per cent a year earlier, while diesel remained stable at around 18 per cent, indicating a gradual move away from conventional internal combustion engines. FADA said FY26 marked a record year for India's auto retail industry, with total vehicle sales crossing 2.96 crore units.

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Freebies unplugged

Their impact on economy, elections, a matter of concern

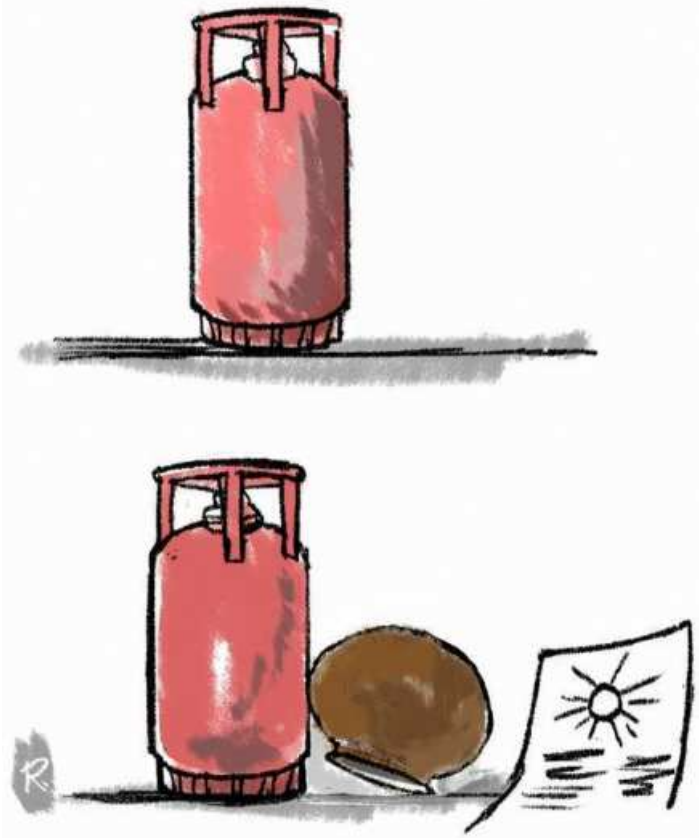
Major political parties, without exception, resort to the dubious practice of announcing ‘freebies’ — unpaid-for welfare measures ranging from free electricity, bus rides, bicycles, laptops, refrigerators, and unconditional cash transfers to girls and women — as elections draw near. We’re witnessing this play out now again as Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Assam go to polls later this month.

In economic terms, freebies have been rightly frowned upon for being cash transfers or other subsidies (free power, bus rides) that eat into resources meant for creating durable assets. Politically, they have drawn flak for conferring an unfair advantage on an incumbent party, as these doles are typically announced closer to polls. A competitive culture of bidding up doles only ends up vitiating free and fair elections. Yet, freebie promises look here to stay, more so unconditional cash transfers (UCTs) to women. For instance, the highlight of the manifesto of Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam is the offer of a ₹8,000 coupon to women in households below the income tax bracket, to buy household electronic goods. Similarly, the United Democratic Front in Kerala promises free bus rides for women and ₹1,000 per month for college girls. The Trinamool Congress’ manifesto builds on its flagship urban cash transfer (UCT) scheme for West Bengal, Lakshmi Bhandar, raising it to ₹1,500 for general women and ₹1,700 for SC/ST women. The BJP’s manifesto is not yet out, but an outreach to women cannot be ruled out — akin to transfers made in Bihar, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Haryana. Apart from UCTs, free ration, transfers to farmers and free electricity are important aspects of India’s welfarism.

The Economic Survey 2025-26 expresses reservations over UCTs to women. The States implementing them increased more than five-fold between FY23 and FY26, with around half of these States estimated to be in revenue deficit. Such transfers are 0.19-1.25 per cent of GSDP and 0.68- 8.26 per cent of the total budgetary expenditures. The 16th Finance Commission has observed that UCTs could account for 20 per cent of total subsidy spending. Power subsidies too account for a major chunk.

As the Survey clarifies, UCTs to women improve consumption, food security, and short-term income stability, but “do not consistently improve child nutrition, educational outcomes, or enable sustained exits from poverty”. For the latter, “investments in health, education, nutrition, childcare, or growth-enhancing public expenditure” are essential. Some freebies create enduring gains — such as Amma Canteens in Tamil Nadu, health insurance, and pensions for ordinary people. As the Survey suggests, freebies can be reformed by making them ‘conditional’, or linked to educational outcomes, such as Brazil’s Bolsa Familia or the midday meal scheme. Their announcement should not coincide with elections. A shift away from UCTs will help.

POCKET RAVIKANTH



GETTY IMAGES



ASHIMA GOYAL

The Middle-East war is causing widespread disruption. But for a number of reasons risk may not be as high as Indian markets seem to be pricing in. There tends to be a knee jerk over-reaction to the impact of global risk-off combined with oil import dependence. This backward looking view neglects many changes.

First, international oil prices crossing \$100 serves as a red flag. But in real terms the shock is not as large as past recent shocks. Brent at \$112 deflated by headline CPI is 57; in June 2022 the deflated value peaked at 71 and stayed high that year, in March 2012 the peak was 130.

Second, there is an above 50 per cent fall in energy intensity since the 1990s with non-fossil fuel sources accounting for 49 per cent of total installed capacity and several green initiatives in place. The power of oil monopolies has fallen. Oil prices are unlikely to stay high because of alternate sources and substitution possibilities. The impact of oil shocks has reduced worldwide because of these reasons.

Third, the starting point is more benign for macro parameters. Some fall in growth and rise in inflation will still be very far from stagflation.

Fourth, it is not clear yet how persistent the shock will be but even if it is, as a scorched earth policy destroys oil infrastructure, we have dealt well with larger past shocks. When the Ukraine conflict started, oil prices stayed high for a year but next year inflation was in the target band, while high growth continued. Indian resilience was due to growing economic diversity and appropriate policy.

Our FTAs can be used more intensively for trade diversification including in oil sourcing. Supply chains are affected, but we have had practice in finding alternatives. The Indian oil basket will change. We may start refining and exporting Iranian and Russian oil to others, reducing shortages.

POLYCRISES PLAYBOOK

If supply disruption persists there is a clear pandemic-Ukraine-playbook to be followed: Counter external shocks as much as possible; keep a moderate liquidity surplus and target support to vulnerable categories but with an automatic sunset clause to prevent perpetual dependence. There were problems in reversing pandemic-time excess liquidity, and with inflation possibly around the corner liquidity infusions have to be measured.

But well-designed support, not tightening, is required in tough times and this worked well in handling recent shocks. We have experience and now just need to apply that consistently.

The government is absorbing much of the current shock, since it may be transient. Counter-cyclical excise cuts limit the pass through to domestic inflation. There is space since the benefit of earlier soft oil prices was not fully passed on to consumers.

While pass through must rise if shocks persist, longer term reforms can moderate it if they act to reduce vulnerabilities. The frontier on substitution and diversification can be pushed. We are surplus in ethanol

If supply disruption persists there is a pandemic-Ukraine-playbook to follow: Counter external shocks as much as possible; keep a moderate liquidity surplus and target support to vulnerable categories

production and already blending has been mandated; distribution of piped natural gas is being enabled. Power distribution reforms will allow green power generation to be fully utilised. Inefficiencies in our fertilizer policy can be reduced and natural farming promoted. When crises force through otherwise intractable reforms future outcomes improve.

The equilibrium real repo rate will stay positive to anchor inflation expectations but will fall below unity as growth slows. Since currently inflation is low, there is space in this policy for the MPC to pause and watch outcomes. A neutral stance will allow data-based response as required.

RUPEE: THE OTHER 100s

But especially when markets are nervous, appropriate communication and guidance is essential. In the February policy there was no clear communication on buying support for G-secs, even though the intent was there. Ten-year G-sec yields rose, disrupting the transmission of rate cuts. Market concern was since durable liquidity was high, open market operations would not occur. Reassurance was required about specific types of liquidity not just aggregate liquidity.

Currently the rupee is under stress. Further implications of the ‘market determined but act to prevent excess volatility’ position need to be drawn out. Unabated excess volatility leads to persistent misalignment, such as a real effective exchange rate (REER) that is almost 10 per cent depreciated over its equilibrium level. Research indicates a REER of 100 remains the equilibrium value. A regime that acts against excess volatility also has to counter this. Rupee depreciation exceeded that of other emerging market (EM) currencies in 2025, but it is continuing to depreciate resulting in severe over-shooting, further raising the cost of oil imports. During global risk-offs EM currencies

are subject to sentiment, overreaction and self-fulfilling panics. Over-depreciation, instead of acting as a shock-absorber, only leads to bets placed to profit from more depreciation. 100 can become a focus for a nominal exchange rate that is nearing it.

Balance is very important. While in 2024 intervention in foreign exchange (FX) markets was too much, in 2025 it was too little. RBI cannot absorb all market-risk but neither can it leave markets to themselves.

In 2013 a hands-off led to a steep depreciation that reversed after a series of intervention, although macro inflation, the current account and fiscal deficit were much worse. Among the most successful measures were a special FX window for oil imports, increasing overseas borrowing limits for banks and a calming speech by the new governor who proceeded to do much more FX intervention. Closing net open positions worked only temporarily and raising interest rates did not work.

During volatile times, especially, the RBI can buy and sell FX to smooth small daily mismatches using their data and knowledge of market microstructure. The reserves are more than adequate for that, dips have always been made up in time. EMs accumulate reserves precisely to have alternatives for a costly interest rate defence. Moreover, such a defence is not compatible with inflation targeting.

It would help to point out that since the 1990s, after large deviations, there always were reversals to a REER of 100. Working with markets does better than forcing them. Both time-dependent assurance as well as hawkish or laissez faire guidance are dangerous in volatile times. But since markets tend to over-react they can be guided broadly towards the equilibrium real rates that affect activity, preventing persistent misalignment. FPI is waiting to be confident of reversal before coming back.

The writer Professor Emeritus, IGIDR

India’s outreach to Angola will contain energy risk

Angola emerges as an important alternative to West Asia in gas supplies. India can rebalance its energy imports

Ganesh Valiachi
Nagarajan M

The disruption of the Strait of Hormuz has exposed a critical fragility in India’s energy architecture, its excessive geographic concentration of imports. With nearly 90 per cent of LPG supply routes affected and about 50 per cent of LNG demand dependent on imports, India’s outreach to Angola is not merely an emergency procurement decision; it is a forced recalibration of trade strategy.

The ongoing negotiations led by Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation, and GAIL Ltd with Sonangol, covering short-term LPG contracts and long-term LNG deals of up to 10 years, signal a shift from opportunistic sourcing to structured engagement. The immediate trigger may be supply disruption from Qatar and the United Arab Emirates, but the implications go far beyond crisis management. What makes Angola significant is not just its 4.6 trillion cubic feet of gas reserves, but its existing position in India’s trade matrix. In FY25, Angola was already India’s fifth-largest

LNG supplier, exporting gas worth \$924 million, trailing only Oman at \$1.04 billion among comparable partners.

This is not a new relationship being built from scratch; it is an underleveraged corridor now being scaled. If the proposed long-term LNG contracts materialise, even a conservative doubling of imports would push Angola into the top tier of India’s gas suppliers, potentially crossing \$2-3 billion annually in trade value.

In parallel, logistical advantages, particularly 10-15 days shorter transit compared to North American shipments, reduce supply lag and inventory costs, which is crucial when domestic sectors like fertilizers and steel are already under strain.

RESHAPING INDO-AFRICAN TRADE India-Africa trade, currently in the range of \$90-100 billion, has long lacked depth despite its scale, remaining concentrated in crude imports and low-value exports. The Angola pivot has the potential to alter this composition in measurable ways. First, it can incrementally shift Africa’s share in India’s energy basket: even a 5-10 per cent substitution of LPG and LNG imports toward African suppliers would



LNG. Diversifying supply sources GETTY IMAGES

reduce dependence on West Asia.

Second, long-term LNG contracts create predictable, high-value trade flows, unlike spot cargoes, embedding Angola more firmly into India’s import structure. A decade-long contract cycle alone could lock in tens of billions of dollars in bilateral trade, creating stability that extends beyond energy into shipping, port infrastructure, and engineering services. Third, such engagement opens the door for Indian firms to move upstream, investing alongside Sonangol, thereby partially offsetting import costs through asset participation. This would mark a shift from a buyer-seller dynamic to an investment-linked trade relationship, something India has historically

pursued in other geographies but only selectively in Africa.

This pivot, however, is not without trade-offs. African gas is unlikely to consistently match the price competitiveness of traditional suppliers like Qatar or the United Arab Emirates, implying a higher landed cost structure for India in the short term. Yet, the Hormuz disruption has made one reality clear: cost efficiency without supply security is economically untenable. The Angola engagement reflects a deliberate shift toward risk-adjusted trade, where diversification carries a premium but reduces exposure to geopolitical chokepoints.

More importantly, it sets a precedent. If scaled beyond Angola to other African producers, India could gradually rebalance its energy imports, reducing regional concentration and embedding Africa more centrally in its trade geography. Angola may not replace West Asia, but it can ensure that India is never again critically dependent on a single corridor.

Valiachi is Assistant Professor at Symbiosis Institute of International Business (SIIB), Pune; Nagarajan is a faculty member of Management Studies at SRM Institute of Science and Technology, Tiruchirappalli

✉ LETTERS TO EDITOR Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Disturbing move

This refers to the Editorial ‘Sweeping powers’ (April 6). The proposed change in the digital media ethics rules, which attempts to put individual social media news-related content providers on par with traditional news institutions, essentially undermines people’s freedom of expression. At a time when the mainstream and corporatised digital news media are losing credibility due to their perceived pro-establishment bias, the new generation of digital media freelancers, many of whom have large subscription bases, has significantly changed the game. The new restrictions will subject all such content makers, particularly those

who are critical of the government, to executive scrutiny.

Under the pretence of promoting ethics in journalistic reporting, the government seeks to muzzle free speech.

Kamal Laddha
Bengaluru

With reference to ‘Sweeping powers’, there is no doubt that the objective of these changes is to ensure a safer and accountable digital ecosystem. But implementing these changes raises serious questions. Government bodies seem to be gaining more authority and control to regulate online content and over digital platforms. Further, the requirement of

intermediaries to take down content within a stipulated time frame may lead to over censorship. This will directly impact journalists and content creators who use digital platforms to express their views freely. Regulation of digital platforms is essential to curb misinformation and harmful content but it is equally important to protect constitutional rights.

Bal Govind
Noida

Sane counsel

The article ‘Sensex at 40: What really drives long-term wealth?’ (April 06), presents a precise take on factors affecting equity returns. The authors’ sane counsel should be the guiding

principle for all who invest in equities. Making the memory of exceptional short-term gains the standard for returns can lead to disappointment and loss by untimely winding down of investment. With the help of statistics the article establishes that investors earn what corporate India delivers as profits: short-term aberrations of fear and euphoria may colour it a bit for a while. Hope this helps readers and investors anchor their investment decisions better.

Jose Abraham
Valkom (Kerala)

Fruit exports on thin ice

The disruption of mango,

pomegranate, grapes, bananas, papaya and guava exports from Karnataka exposes a systemic fragility in our agricultural strategy. Relying on volatile markets like West Asia has left growers vulnerable to geopolitical tremors. Other exotic fruits like avocado, dragon and jack fruit also face similar bottlenecks. Diversifying to the UK and Canada is a start but without government backed insurance against regional conflicts and subsidized cold-chain logistics, farmers remain at the mercy of middlemen. We need robust direct-to-market channels and domestic processing hubs.

Vijaykumar HK
Raichur



QUICKLY.

Equirus Securities ties up with Aletheia Capital



Chennai: Equirus Securities has joined hands with Aletheia Capital and appointed Jim Walker, Aletheia's Chief Economist, as Global Economic Advisor. Aletheia and Walker will strengthen Equirus' global macro research capabilities for institutional clients, it said in a statement. Vishad Turakhia, CEO, Equirus Securities, said, "Walker brings a distinctive and independent perspective on global economic cycles, which will significantly strengthen the depth of our research and client engagement. His insights will be valuable in helping our institutional clients interpret macro shifts and position portfolios with greater clarity."

Bajaj Alternate gets SEBI nod for PMS licence

New Delhi: Bajaj Alternate Investment Management, an arm of Bajaj Finserv, on Monday said it has received approval from SEBI to commence portfolio management services (PMS). The move will help Bajaj Alts expand its footprint in listed equities. With this, the firm strengthens its position as a diversified investment platform offering comprehensive solutions across Alternative Investment Funds and PMS, the company said in a statement. "The PMS licence marks a strategic step in our journey to build a differentiated investment platform for discerning investors. It allows us to be a trusted partner in our investors' wealth creation journey. As investor portfolios evolve, there is a growing need for customised and actively managed solutions."

SEBI plans joint drive to strengthen independent directors' role

NAGGING ISSUES. Pandey flags 'gap in translation' of governance norms; global disruptions add to risks

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is working on a collaborative framework with corporates, academia and professional bodies to strengthen the pipeline and effectiveness of independent directors (IDs), Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said. "SEBI will seek to embark on a joint initiative for capacity building of independent directors at scale with a view to further improving corporate governance," the Chairman said at the 19th Governance Summit, hosted by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), on Monday. The remarks assume significance amid recent board-

room developments, including at HDFC Bank, which have brought the role and effectiveness of IDs under scrutiny. "We are meeting at a tumultuous time, with war in West Asia choking oil and gas supplies, triggering global price shocks, with severe impact on the world economy....," Pandey said. "In such an environment, governance is no longer about preventing what can go wrong. It is equally about enabling institutions to respond wisely when uncertainty arises."

'UNCERTAINTY' "Markets, as we know, can absorb business risk, but they respond sharply to governance uncertainty," he said, adding that as investor



PRESSURE POINT. Markets can absorb business risk but they respond sharply to governance uncertainty, Pandey said

participation deepens, the expectations from boards also increase. He said boards are well-constituted, but not always equally effective, with variations in how IDs engage and challenge management. "What we are increasingly observing is a gap, not in in-

terests of the minority shareholders.... not only for compliance and pointing fingers at management but also for supporting and finding solutions through accountability. They need to bear this responsibility in mind," Pandey said.

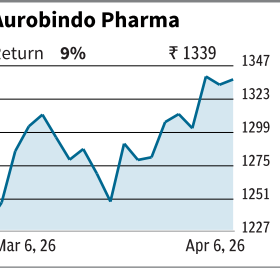
CONTINUOUS LEARNING The proposed initiative will focus on continuous learning, domain-specific orientation and stronger knowledge-sharing platforms to help directors navigate areas such as technology, cyber risks and complex financial structures. Pandey said a shift in boardroom approach is required, from information to insight and from compliance-driven reviews to value-driven discussions.

Aurobindo Pharma board clears ₹800 crore buyback

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The board of Aurobindo Pharma on Monday approved a proposal to buyback up to 54.23 lakh fully paid-up equity shares of the company, each with a face value of ₹1 representing up to 0.93 per cent of the total paid-up equity share capital. The buyback will be at ₹1,475 a share payable in cash, for an aggregate amount up to ₹800 crore.

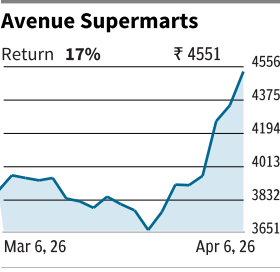
COST EXCLUSIONS The buyback size does not include transaction costs such as brokerage costs, fees,



Avenue Supermarts surges 4.33% as better Q4 estimate lifts sentiment

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Avenue Supermarts (DMart) closed higher on Monday, ending at ₹4,551.30 on the NSE — up 4.33 per cent or ₹188.90 from the previous close of ₹4,362.40 — as investors continued to price in a stronger-than-expected quarterly revenue performance. The stock touched an intra-day high of ₹4,562.60. The move came on the back of DMart's Q4-FY26 revenue showed standalone revenue from operations rising 19 per cent year-on-year to ₹17,204.50 crore —



sharply ahead of analyst estimates of around 15 per cent growth and a significant recovery from the 13 per cent posted in Q3-FY26. The stock has now returned 17 per cent over the past month and 22 per cent year-to-date, comfortably

outpacing the Nifty Next 50, which is down 6.84 per cent and 9.78 per cent over the same periods respectively.

MIXED VIEWS However, analysts' views remained split on valuation. Motilal Oswal reiterated a 'Buy' with a target of ₹5,000, projecting 19 per cent revenue CAGR over FY26-28 driven by accelerating store additions. JM Financial maintained a 'Reduce' at ₹4,500, warning that elevated capex of around ₹51,335 crore in FY26 would keep free cash flow negative through FY28 and push the balance sheet into net debt.

NSE to launch Brent crude futures based on Platts benchmark

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange of India has entered into a strategic collaboration with S&P Global Energy to introduce exchange-traded derivatives based on its Platts physical spot market benchmarks. Having received SEBI approval, NSE will initially launch Dated Brent Crude Oil (Platts) futures contracts based on the Platts Dated Brent benchmark. The Exchange has announced that it will launch the contracts on April 13. A part of S&P Global Energy, Platts is a leading independent provider of information, data, analysis, benchmark prices and workflow solutions for the commodities markets. The move marks a significant step in deepening India's



energy derivatives ecosystem and aligning it with globally recognised pricing standards. The exchange aims to provide market participants a robust, transparent and globally relevant risk management tool linked to internationally trusted energy reference prices.

MARKET ACCESS The proposed contracts are designed to aid a wide spectrum of market participants, including refiners, importers, traders, financial institutions and investors seeking exposure to global Brent

crude oil markets through a regulated domestic platform. Sriram Krishnan, Chief Business Development Officer, NSE, said by introducing derivatives on Platts benchmarks, starting with Brent crude oil, the exchange aims to offer market participants credible and efficient tools for price discovery and risk management. These products will bridge domestic and international markets, while enhancing India's position in the global energy trading ecosystem, he said. Platts benchmarks are widely used across global commodity markets and exchanges, and their integration into NSE's derivatives offerings is expected to bring enhanced transparency, credibility, and alignment with the nation's relevant crude oil variety pricing mechanisms.

Valura.ai attracts over 1,000 wealth advisors

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Valura.ai, an AI-native global investment platform, has onboarded over 1,000 wealth advisors across India ahead of its official launch, with a collective AUM pipeline exceeding ₹3,000 crore over the next 12-18 months. The onboarded network includes independent financial advisors, registered investment advisors, mutual fund distributors and chartered accountants. The pre-launch response signals strong demand for a credible global investing infrastructure at a time when India's outbound investment surged 67 per cent to \$41.6 billion in FY25 and the rupee has depreciated over 8 per cent against the US dollar in the past twelve months. Valura.ai is a multi-asset investment platform, allowing exposure across equities, ETFs, global mutual funds, bonds, REITs and pre-IPO opportunities.

Mesabi Metallics secures \$150 million investment from Macquarie Group

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Mesabi Metallics Company LLC, backed by the Essar Group, has secured \$150 million in financing from the Macquarie Group to support the Q3 2026 startup of its Direct Reduction grade iron ore mine and pellet plant in Minnesota. The financing follows Mesabi's recently announced \$520 million senior secured credit facility with Breakwall Capital. Mesabi also recently received support from the US Export-Import Bank.

MINE EXPANSION Mesabi Metallics is completing a \$2.5 billion world-scale merchant DR-grade iron ore mine and pellet plant that will supply the next generation electric arc furnaces of American steel making.

With more than 800 construction workers currently onsite, the Essar Group has already invested more than \$2 billion of equity into the project. Joe Broking, President and CEO, Mesabi Metallics, said the financing from Macquarie marks another major step forward for the company and builds on the strong momentum established with recently announced financial partnerships. Mike Burns, Senior Managing Director in the Macquarie Group's Commodities and Global Markets business, said Mesabi is developing a high-quality and strategically important project for the US steel sector and Macquarie looks forward to supporting the company over the long term.

BROKER'S CALL.

ICICI Securities

ORIENT ELECTRIC (BUY)
Target: ₹200
CMP: ₹161.15
Q4-FY26 is shaping up to be a decent quarter for Orient Electric (Orient), aided by stable demand across fans, lighting, switchgear and wires. We note that it has taken calibrated price hikes of about 4-5 per cent in fans in Q4FY26 and we expect further price hikes in coming quarters to offset inflationary pressure; it continues to focus on premiumisation, especially in BLDC fans, to support margins; lighting segment could outgrow peers, with consumer lighting and premiumisation tracking well, though sourcing and pricing may remain volatile; Air cooler sales may be impacted by unseasonal rains in late Mar'26 in North India; and Switchgear and wires are expected to grow in high double digits, albeit on a low base; however, procurement-linked volatility may impact the supply chain. The focus remains on increasing the share of BLDC fans, which should likely support realisations and margins going ahead, in our view While near-term margins may see some pressure due to the partial passthrough of costs, we believe a gradual recovery is likely led by the improvement in product mix and operating leverage. We model Orient to report revenue and PAT CAGR of 11.7 per cent and 25.4 per cent, respectively, over FY25-28E. We expect RoE to remain above 13 per cent over FY26-28E. We maintain Buy with a DCF-based revised target price of ₹200 (earlier ₹210). **Key risks:** Steep increase in competitive pressures and commodity inflation.

Kotak Institutional Equities

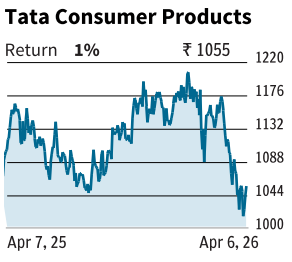
EMMVEE PHOTOVOLTAIC (ADD)
Target: ₹250
CMP: ₹223.80
We initiate coverage on Emmvee Photovoltaic with an Add rating and a DCF based Fair Value of ₹250 (13.0X March 2028E EPS). Our FV implies Emmvee capacity to see 10/15 per cent CAGR for module and cell capacities, respectively, 20/30 per cent volume CAGR for Emmvee's module and cell volumes until FY35, driven by capacity addition and utilisation levels of about 60 per cent for modules and 80 per cent for cells, a contraction of EBITDA margins from 34 per cent in FY25 to 14 per cent in FY35, factoring in heightened competitive intensity, a cost of equity of 14.5 per cent and WACC of 11.6 per cent and terminal value of 1.5X FY35 book value (in line with Chinese solar companies' valuations). Emmvee is currently setting up a 6 GW integrated cell and module manufacturing unit, which will take its total capacity to 16.3 GW and 8.9 GW module and cell, respectively, making it the fourth largest player in India. Given the implementation of ALMM list II from June 1, 2026, this will enable Emmvee to benefit from superior profitability relative to peers in the medium term. **Key risks:** Lack of diversification away from the solar PV module value chain, increasing margin risks, changes in the domestic policy environment, delay in getting cell capacity on stream, slower-than-expected growth in renewable capacity addition and faster-than-expected ramp-up of competitors' cell capacities.

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TODAY'S PICK.

Tata Consumer Products (₹1,055.80): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Tata Consumer Products has been in a downtrend for over a month now. But the price action over the past couple of weeks suggests that the bears are losing traction as the movement has largely been sideways. In addition, the scrip formed a bullish pin bar candlestick on the weekly chart and although not a textbook definition, the daily chart shows formation of a morning star pattern. Notably, these patterns have formed on the back of long-term trendline support. Hence, there are signs of a rally in the near-term.

The upswing can lift the stock to ₹1,120. So, buy at ₹1,050 and ₹1,020. Place stop-loss at ₹990. On a rally to ₹1,075 and ₹1,100, revise stop-loss to ₹1,050 and ₹1,080 respectively. Exit at ₹1,120. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23050 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
22850	22600	23300	23600	Buy if there is a rebound from 22850; stop-loss can be at 22600.	

₹771 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
755	730	795	815	Chart shows bullish bias; buy now and at 755 with stop-loss at 720.	

₹1306 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1290	1260	1320	1350	Go long if the stock breaks out of 1320; stop-loss can be 1300.	

₹294 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
292	288	298	308	No clear direction indicated on the chart; refrain from trading.	

₹281 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
280	275	290	300	Buy if the stock rises above 290; stop-loss can be at 280.	

₹1304 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1290	1270	1330	1350	Chart appears bearish; sell below 1290 with stop-loss at 1330.	

₹1032 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1020	1000	1065	1090	Price action hints at a rally; go long with a stop-loss at 1000.	

₹2473 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2440	2400	2480	2550	Go long if the stock breaks out of 2480; stop-loss can be 2440.	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Sensex, Nifty gain for 3rd day amid Iran-US truce talk

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai



The markets staged a broad-based recovery on Monday, with the Nifty 50 closing at 22,968, up 255 points and the BSE Sensex settling at 74,107, a gain of 787 points or 1.07 per cent, marking the third consecutive session of positive closes — a trend, analysts say, signals a gradual easing of selling pressure. Ajit Mishra, SVP Research, Religare Broking, attributed the recovery in part to geopolitical signals, noting the upmove was "primarily driven by reports of a potential ceasefire framework in the Middle East, which helped stabilise crude prices". He, however, cautioned that "concerns around foreign institutional outflows, currency volatility, and potential earnings downgrades continue to linger."

time. While geopolitical events may temporarily weigh on economic momentum, such developments rarely undermine long-term structural growth narratives, it said. Trent emerged as the session's top Nifty gainer while Shriram Finance and Axis Bank also featured among the top movers. Broader markets showed relative resilience. The Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 both rose about 1.5 per cent, with the Smallcap 100 surging above its 13-day EMA for the first time since February 25. Of the BSE 500 universe, 385 stocks ended in the green.

'RELIEF RALLY' India VIX, despite the negative cloze, continued to hold above 25, an elevated reading that signals uncertainty remains deeply embedded. Ponmudi R, CEO, Enrich Money, said, "Today's recovery was largely a relief rally driven by short covering, easing crude prices, and absence of fresh negative triggers, rather than a strong fundamental shift."

Looking ahead, the week carries a dense macro calendar — the RBI monetary policy decision, US CPI data, crude oil trajectory, and geopolitical developments are all expected to drive sentiment. TCS reports earnings on April 9, with ICICI AMC and ICICI Prudential Life following later in the week, setting up a critical test for market direction.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 255.15 pts
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
HDFC Bank	771.00	67.11	15.33	11.21	
Axis Bank	1245.30	29.67	14.65	3.39	
L&I	3727.70	29.35	27.02	7.00	
ICICI Bank	1231.40	24.33	15.57	8.36	
Bajaj Finance	850.85	14.01	28.89	2.16	
Trent Ltd.	3833.60	13.70	84.13	0.81	
Titan	4246.10	13.40	79.09	1.66	
State Bank	1032.75	12.99	11.02	4.07	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	928.00	11.12	19.09	1.23	
UltraTech Cement	10955.00	8.65	42.13	1.23	
NTPC	366.10	6.62	14.30	1.65	
SBI Life	1836.80	6.15	74.31	0.78	
IntGlobalBevi	4312.50	5.87	51.93	0.93	
TCS	2473.90	5.17	18.66	2.40	
PowerGrid Corp	295.15	5.14	17.68	1.27	
Coal India	459.55	5.05	9.52	0.99	
Bajaj Auto	8942.50	4.45	28.13	0.94	
Bharat Elec	427.15	4.34	52.36	1.45	
ITC	294.85	4.21	17.84	2.70	
Grasim Ind	2614.40	4.18	18.78	0.95	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	235.31	4.17	93.16	0.73	
Infosys	1306.20	4.13	18.92	4.35	
Kotak Bank	360.55	4.04	19.08	2.52	
Bajaj Finserv	1672.30	3.98	13.94	0.92	
Adani Enter	1902.20	3.86	15.54	0.47	
NestleIndia	1216.00	3.86	71.89	0.83	
Hind Unilever	2084.80	3.78	48.72	1.83	
Hindalco	927.45	3.54	12.96	1.28	
Tata Steel	196.10	3.53	26.84	1.54	
HDFC Life	580.00	3.25	65.25	0.59	
Bharti Airtel	1792.80	2.08	29.48	5.23	
M&M	3021.60	1.93	22.23	2.56	
TataConsumerProduct	1055.20	1.88	70.96	0.65	
Tata Motors PV	307.40	1.87	41.80	0.61	
Maruti Suzuki	12688.00	1.63	26.72	1.58	
Adani Ports	1287.15	1.53	25.57	0.97	
Asian Paints	2184.30	1.51	53.58	0.94	
Wipro	197.29	1.48	15.52	0.54	
Apollo Hosp	7373.00	1.25	56.82	0.72	
Tech Mahindra	1449.50	1.11	30.93	0.87	
Cipla	1200.90	1.04	21.40	0.64	
Eternal Ltd.	232.20	0.75	970.05	1.39	
HCL Tech	1403.30	0.25	23.12	1.41	
Sun Pharma	1694.60	0.23	37.12	1.70	
Dr Reddys Lab	1217.80	0.07	18.40	0.70	
JSW Steel	1133.60	-1.58	35.70	1.01	
Eicher Motors	6596.00	-1.61	33.77	0.86	
MH Healthcare	931.60	-2.11	63.88	0.66	
ONGC	281.85	-4.53	7.88	1.04	
Reliance Ind	1304.70	-67.49	18.06	8.37	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 901.35 pts
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Avenuesuper	4551.30	78.51	103.40	3.01	
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3487.80	63.91	54.26	3.68	
AdaniGreenenergy	921.10	61.61	81.75	1.39	
Bank Of Baroda	259.76	53.42	6.84	2.16	
Adani Energy Solutions	691.35	48.72	49.36	1.54	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1393.20	44.61	24.49	2.68	
Adani Power .	163.26	38.41	27.86	3.03	
Hindustaneronautics	3752.10	34.87	28.21	3.20	
Muthootfin	3289.80	33.60	15.26	1.58	
Canara Bank	1306.51	33.03	6.43	1.98	
Bosch	33460.00	32.44	35.80	1.30	
Indian Hotels Co.	595.40	31.36	39.16	2.35	
Britannia Ind	5535.00	30.93	55.17	2.93	
Hdfc Amc	2386.60	21.85	35.58	2.18	
Shree Cement	23965.00	21.52	47.60	1.42	
Ambuja Cements	4300.05	19.97	21.60	1.81	
Cummins India	4698.30	19.75	58.10	2.85	
Punjab Natl Bank	106.50	19.66	6.85	1.65	
Tata Motors Cv	391.30	18.88	87.50	3.67	
Samvardhamothersoninternat	108.26	18.12	31.40	2.15	
Bajaj Holdings	9131.00	16.93	11.34	1.78	
Pidilittind	1291.20	15.41	56.79	1.80	
Power Finance	405.90	15.00	4.01	2.65	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	687.30	14.04	97.56	2.12	
Solar Industries	13303.00	13.34	78.85	1.46	
Hindus Zinc	526.05	12.60	18.83	1.02	
DIF	529.20	12.59	29.58	1.52	
United Spirits .	1236.30	12.59	52.28	1.64	
Union Bank	174.12	11.62	7.02	1.51	
Macrotech Developers .	710.25	11.29	21.21	0.90	
Vedanta	1127.25	11.27	16.28	5.77	
GAIL (India)	143.14	10.74	10.94	1.73	
Mazagon Dock	2313.70	10.53	19.78	1.75	
Rail Elec	327.55	9.70	5.00	1.84	
Gudrej Consumer	1001.95	8.12	56.28	1.81	
Abb India	6193.50	7.63	77.83	1.86	
Trent Pharma	446.60	7.20	59.13	1.46	
Siemens	3048.50	5.34	68.46	1.21	
Indian Railway Finance	92.72	5.00	17.29	0.84	
Bpcl	278.70	3.15	4.91	2.54	
Siemens Energy India	2620.20	2.05	78.99	0.74	
ZydusIntellsciences	866.30	1.45	17.34	1.97	
UPL Industries	432.40	0.92	44.25	1.42	
Tata Capital	308.00	-0.67	28.63	0.60	
Indian Oilcorp	514.00	-0.84	5.13	2.25	
Jindal Steel	1134.00	-4.08	57.38	1.89	
Tata Power	383.85	-5.43	24.49	2.89	
Hyundai Motor India	1091.40	-8.09	23.74	1.08	
Varun Beverages .	5821.00	-10.43	44.29	2.46	
Divis Lab	5821.00	-12.74	62.37	3.92	

Pts: Impact on index movement

GROUND REPORT

Matua community feels left out after SIR exercise

NO HOPE? Awaiting citizenship, members feel BJP and TMC are playing with sentiments

Mithun Dasgupta
Thakurnagar (North 24 Parganas)

The evening was cooler than usual after showers earlier in the day but the conversation was heating up among the devotees sitting on the temple premises.

“Can you vote this time? Voter deletion has been rampant. In our booth, 100 names got deleted,” a middle-aged man in dhoti told a man sitting next to him. He promptly replied: “Well, I can cast my vote. My name is there in the voter list. Is your name there? They even deleted the names of voters who had been casting their votes here for the last 10 years. You know they deleted the names of Trinamool supporters only. It is only hurting the reputation of BJP.”

SIR EXERCISE

Their conversation about the ongoing SIR exercise in electoral rolls, which has sparked massive resentment among the Matua community in Thakurnagar, broke off as puja bells and drums began ringing at the Harichand Thakur Mandir first and then at the Guruchand Thakur Mandir.

Harichand Thakur, born into the Namasudra family in East Bengal (now Bangladesh) in the early nineteenth century, was the founder of the Matua sect for a socio-religious reform movement. His son Guruchand Thakur intensified the anti-caste movement. Matuas migrated to India and formed a large colony in Thakurnagar, in West Bengal’s North 24 Par-



VOICE OF THE VOICELESS. The Matua community taking out a rally against the Special Intensive Revision in Kolkata (ANI FILE PHOTO)

ganas district bordering Bangladesh (then East Pakistan) in 1948, a year after Partition.

BANGLADESH CLASHES

Matua community members migrated in different phases during the communal clashes in Bangladesh to Thakurnagar, their heartland located about 90 km from Kolkata. However, a sizeable number are yet to get Indian citizenship.

“Our community members are politically divided between BJP and Trinamool Congress. But both BJP and Trinamool are playing with our sentiments. The saffron party is trying to lure Matuas by promising to grant citizenship through the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA). However, so far I have not witnessed a single

case where a person belonging to our community got citizenship through CAA. Trinamool is criticising the BJP for the deletion of a large number of voters from voters list during the SIR, but the party is not serious about our members getting citizenship,” said 70-year-old Bikash Bala, who was born here and whose father was one of the migrants from Bangladesh.

The Matuas now form West Bengal’s second largest Scheduled Caste (SC) population. They are mostly concentrated in North and South 24 Parganas and Nadia, apart from bordering districts such as Howrah, Cooch Behar, North and South Dinajpur and Malda. The community constitutes around 17 per cent of the total voters in the State.

The Gaighata constituency, under which Thakurnagar falls, is generally considered a BJP stronghold as it is the backyard of party MP and Matua leader Shantanu Thakur. Gaighata BJP MLA and prominent Matua leader Subrata Thakur is the older brother of Shantanu Thakur.

Subrata is seeking re-election and is contesting against TMC’s Narottam Biswas in the Assembly elections scheduled for April 29.

“For the huge deletion of names during the SIR exercise, BJP is facing some resentment. Trinamool can draw heart from it. This time there will be a tight contest. Anyone can win from Gaighata constituency and the wining margin will be very thin,” said Bholanath Biswas, a voter belonging to the constituency.

DMK has failed to implement Central schemes, says Goyal

Our Bureau
Chennai

Senior BJP leader and Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal accused the DMK government led by MK Stalin of failing to implement key Central schemes in Tamil Nadu.

Despite substantial financial support from the Centre, the State government has not effectively utilised funds or extended scheme benefits to eligible citizens, he told mediapersons at the party headquarters on Monday.

HOUSING SCHEME

Citing housing as an example, he said over nine lakh houses had been sanctioned for Tamil Nadu under Central schemes.

However, the State government had failed to submit the beneficiary details for nearly three lakh families.

“These are poor families who could have received houses with basic amenities. I want to ask what the State government has against them,” he said.

He also alleged that funds under schemes such as the Jal Jeevan Mission were not being fully utilised due to issues such as alleged irregularities in contract allocation.

“In this mission, massive corruption has been found in the contracts given by the Stalin government. An investigation is going on to check who are the ministers involved, whether the CM is directly responsible for that corruption, and I assure the people of Tamil Nadu we will make these ministers and the CM accountable for the corruption of the last five years,” he said.

On tax devolution to Tamil Nadu, Goyal said it had doubled compared to previ-



Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal

ous years, while grants-in-aid had risen substantially.

GRANTS-IN-AID

According to him, grants-in-aid to Tamil Nadu during the 2004-2014 period averaged around ₹57,000 crore, but rose to about ₹2.5 lakh crore under the current dispensation. Goyal argued that instead of confronting the Centre, the State government should collaborate to ensure the effective delivery of welfare schemes and infrastructure development.

He criticised the DMK government over delays in implementing other Central initiatives, alleging that political differences were affecting welfare delivery.

TN MANIFESTO

Drawing a parallel with his experience in trade negotiations, Goyal said the party’s manifesto for Tamil Nadu cannot be rushed.

“When I used to negotiate free trade agreements, the press would always ask about the timeframe. I always said I don’t negotiate with a gun to my head,” he remarked, adding that the party would take the necessary time to finalise a “very powerful” manifesto.

QUICKLY.

Amit Shah holds roadshow in Kerala

Thiruvananthapuram: Union Home Minister and BJP leader Amit Shah on Monday held a roadshow in Alappuzha ahead of the elections in Kerala on April 9. Earlier in the day, Shah attended the BJP’s 47th foundation day event at the party office in Thiruvananthapuram. The event marked the celebration of the party’s establishment, with BJP leaders and cadres participating. They also sang ‘Vande Mataram’ and hoisted the BJP flag. Shah’s presence underscored the party’s focus on strengthening its base in Kerala ahead of the upcoming Assembly elections.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi lauded the dedication and sacrifices of BJP workers, saying they endured every hardship — from the Emergency and Congress-era oppression to political violence in Bengal — to serve the nation.

Addressing BJP workers via video conference on the party’s Foundation Day, Modi said, “BJP workers never hesitate when it comes to raising issues connected to the people. Many *karyakartas* even sacrificed their lives.”

Reflecting on the 1984 elections, he added, “Congress won a record number of seats, but India also witnessed how they betrayed the people. This increased trust in the BJP, and slowly we began to win seats.” **ANI**

‘UDF will ensure the safety of women’

Thrissur: The UDF government will build a shield around the people of Kerala by ensuring women’s safety and strengthening social and healthcare systems, said Rahul Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, at an election rally in Thrissur. “We are headed for difficult times on account of the wars in Ukraine and Iran. If the wars continue, prices will rise significantly, and that is why we want to set up a protective layer for every Keralite,” he said. He accused both the LDF government in Kerala and Narendra Modi-led NDA government of arrogance. He drew attention to the LDF billboards that portrayed campaign slogans such as ‘who else’, as if “there is no one else to rule the State”, he said. With the election just days away, Gandhi was addressing a packed audience in an open-air ground in Kunnankulam, urging voters to back UDF candidates across the key constituencies in Thrissur. Gandhi said one in three youths in Kerala is unemployed, and blamed the LDF for the brain drain and degeneration of the health sector. **RAVI MG**

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Rohan G Das**

Big ideas, bigger pledges

A comparison of various promises made by Tamil Nadu parties — DMK, AIADMK, TVK — on key themes such as women’s welfare, education, LPG and agriculture

Theme	DMK	AIADMK	TVK
Women’s welfare schemes	- Monthly assistance of ₹2,000 - Interest-free loan of ₹5 lakh for women self help groups	- Monthly assistance of ₹2,000 ₹1,000 during pongal and free deepavali sarees ₹10,000 grant for women to start businesses	- Monthly assistance of ₹2,500 - Gold and wedding saree for women getting married - Interest-free loan of ₹5 lakh for women self help groups - Free sanitary pad distribution
Cash/commodity transfers	₹8,000 coupon for appliances like fridge, washing machine, AC	- One time relief of ₹10,000 to every family to manage ‘tax burden and price rise’ - Free refrigerator	Gold ring, baby welcome kit for newborns
LPG	-	3 free LPG cylinder per year	6 free LPG cylinders per year
Education	- Monthly higher education assistance of ₹1,500 for girls who completed education in government schools - Monthly higher education assistance of ₹1,500 for boys who completed education in government schools - Extension of breakfast scheme to students until class 8 - Laptops for 35 lakh higher education students	- Reservation for government school students at medical colleges increased from 7 to 10 per cent - Free laptops for students in government colleges - Waiver of education loans to students who have not secured employment	₹15,000 annually to the mother or guardian of students from class 1 to 12 to prevent drop out - No collateral, interest-free loans up to ₹20 lakh for students 12th - PhD - Five lakh internship opportunities with ₹10,000 stipend - Free higher education for children of farmers
Employment	- Training, industry exposure and ₹1,500 stipend under ‘Naan Muthalvan Scheme’ - Upskill and create jobs for 50 lakh students in five years - District-level sector-specific training for 1 lakh people - Monthly pensions of ₹2,000 through welfare boards	₹2,000 for unemployed graduate youth, ₹1,000 for 12th standard pass - Expanding MNREGA Scheme to 150 days 75 per cent of private jobs to Tamils	₹4,000 for unemployed graduates and ₹2,000 for unemployed diploma holders - No collateral, interest-free loans of ₹25 lakh for ‘honest’ young entrepreneurs 75 per cent of private jobs to Tamils
Alcohol & drugs	—	- Anti-drug task force under CM. Arrest of drug peddlers - Gradual prohibition, close liquor shops in a phased manner	Anti-drug forums, strict laws for ban of drugs
Mobility	Free bus travel for women (continuation)	- Free bus travel for both men and women - Amma two-wheelers with a subsidy of ₹25,000 to 5 lakh for working women	Free bus travel for women
Industry development	₹18 lakh crore in industrial investments of which ₹5 lakh will be MSME investments ₹120 billion export capabilities 500 GCCs ₹50,000 crore investments in semiconductor ecosystem	- Textile parks, pharmaceutical parks, defence corridors ‘Satellite software parks’ in Chennai and other district for 200 software companies	—
Agriculture	- Up to ₹25,000 compensation for crop loss due to natural disasters and floods - Free modern electric pump sets - Subsidies to purchase agricultural machinery	₹15,000 subsidy for fertilizer and seeds - Drones for pesticide spraying, solar pump sets for low rent	Full and partial loan waivers based on land size

Press Trust of India
Nagaon (Assam)

Hours after Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma denied Congress allegations regarding his wife allegedly holding multiple passports and properties abroad, Lok Sabha MP Gaurav Gogoi on Monday challenged the BJP leader to deny the claims under oath on the Bhagavad Gita.

DUBAI CONNECTION

Responding to Gogoi’s allegations, the CM’s wife Riniki

Bhuyan Sharma said that neither she nor her children nor her husband own any business in any foreign country.

A day after Congress leaders Pawan Khera and Gogoi sought to know whether Sarma’s wife had three foreign passports, owns property in Dubai, has companies in the US or has placed assets in shell companies, the CM on Monday claimed the Opposition party had concocted the charges using false information from a Pakistani social media group.

Speaking to reporters



Riniki Bhuyan Sharma

after an election rally in Raha, the Assam Congress President questioned Sarma and asked whether he was hiding assets and business interests abroad while

spreading falsehoods about rivals. “I said this yesterday, and I am again repeating it now. I can say under an oath on the Bhagavad Gita that I don’t have any property in London as alleged by Sarma. Can he do that? I challenge him to come to a common place and to do the same under an oath on the Bhagavad Gita,” said Gogoi.

He asserted that if such properties were not declared in the election affidavit, Sarma cannot accept their existence now, as it would lead to the cancellation of his candidature.

Ahead of polls, Kerala parties wage a poster war

Ravi MG
Thrissur

The Left Democratic Front’s mammoth billboards tower over those of the United Democratic Front (UDF) and the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) along the Palakkad-Thrissur highway. They rose from a sweep of green by the lake and beneath the thick cover of trees, interrupted only by a kilometre-long twin-tube Kuthiran tunnel and stone arch bridges.

A ride into the city centre in an electric autorickshaw, gliding over recently laid roads, revealed more billboards from all parties — candidates smiling down at the people, rather than engaging with them on the ground.

A special mention goes to the LDF’s hoardings that portrayed a larger-than-life picture of Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, wearing a calm yet measured smile. The billboards dominated by strokes of mostly red, purple and green remained discreet without overshadowing the leader.

They highlighted the party’s achievements — women’s safety, uninterrupted ration supply, jobs and devel-



LARGER THAN LIFE. The LDF’s road campaigns appear few and far between, but they have gone big on hoardings

opment — while other parties’ hoardings detailed their public outreach and sought a mandate to oust the sitting MLAs.

Political rivals came together to set the billboard phenomenon rolling across Kerala as they simply did not have enough time for canvassing due to the limited timeframe given by the Election Commission which, however, was generous to Tamil Nadu and West Bengal that are going to the polls towards the end of April.

CAMPAIGN STYLE

QR codes on some of the

hoardings made up for the lost engagement, inviting voters to access information about the party, its promises and policies.

Driver Joby PV, engaged enthusiastically in a poll chat, and said parties seem to have made a shift in their campaign style this time. LDF’s road campaigns appear few and far between, but they have gone big on hoardings, said the 45-year-old.

Flower vendors and lottery ticket agents at a sprawling intersection at the mouth of the city centre were witnesses to the giant hoardings

being set up. “Few rallies were held at key locations here, but otherwise the hoardings are all what we are left with,” they said.

Campaign boards of key contenders, some occasionally gigantic, sat snugly amid the signages of popular food chains, clothing outlets and supermarkets. The result resembled a poster war, one that the ruling party appears to be winning hands down.

‘A SHEER WASTE’

Fifty-seven-year-old Suresh P, Deputy Manager at a civil construction establishment, said the grandiose billboards were a sheer waste of government funds by the LDF.

There were posters against kerbs, on walls and tree trunks — presenting candidates dressed in their election best and flashing winning smiles in a quiet co-existence — to catch the eye of the people of Thrissur, who are dividing their attention between the election and the *Thrissur Pooram* festivities unfolding around the 1,600-year-old Sree Vadakkumnathan Temple.

With the poster war serving as a precursor to the election around the corner, the battle for visibility has found space in every nook and cranny of the State.

QUICKLY.

Hilary Maxson is Oracle's new CFO



Oracle appointed Hilary Maxson as Chief Financial Officer, tapping an executive with experience in infrastructure and energy to steer its efforts to meet surging demand for artificial intelligence and cloud services. The appointment comes as the technology company has been taking on a heavy debt load to fuel its massive AI infrastructure spending. Maxson, whose appointment is effective immediately, had served as Group CFO at Schneider Electric, an energy management and automation company, Oracle said. REUTERS

Iran rejects ceasefire before Trump ultimatum expires

MEASURED RESPONSE. US President on Monday described the latest proposal from Iran as a ‘very significant step’ but not enough to end the fighting

Bloomberg

Iran rejected a proposed ceasefire as a deadline from President Donald Trump looms to re-open the Strait of Hormuz or face further attacks on civilian infrastructure. The rejection, delivered through mediator Pakistan, is the latest blow to efforts to end the month-long war that has triggered a global energy crisis. Trump on Monday described the latest proposal from Iran as a “very significant step” but not enough to end the fighting. US allies are

reportedly pressing for a last-minute deal with Iran, as Trump extended his deadline to Tuesday for Tehran to reopen the vital waterway, keeping markets on edge over whether a breakthrough can be reached. Axios reported that Pakistan, Egypt and Turkey are pushing to secure a potential ceasefire — lasting about 45 days — to head off threatened US strikes on Iran’s energy infrastructure and retaliation by the Islamic Republic against countries in the region.

OIL PRICES

Oil prices were little changed on Monday and swung between losses and gains as traders remain focused on real world movement of oil barrels. Brent crude traded near \$108 a barrel while US

crude hovered near \$110 a barrel. Fighting continued, with Israel, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates reporting Iranian attacks overnight into Monday. Israel struck Iran’s biggest petrochemical facility, which is responsible for 50 per cent of the petrochemical production in the country, Defence Minister Israel Katz said. In an expletive-laced post on Sunday, Trump threatened to destroy Iran’s power plants and blow up “everything over there,” before announcing what appeared to be a new Tuesday 8 pm deadline, without offering details. The move adds to a series of extensions since he began issuing similar ultimatums on March 21 to force Iran to reopen the strategic waterway.



FINAL WARNING. US President Donald Trump said the Tuesday deadline he has set for Iran to make a deal is final REUTERS

ONGOING TALKS

The repeated delays come as Trump points to ongoing negotiations between his envoys and Iran’s leadership, which he has yet to identify, aimed at ending the war triggered by US and Israeli attacks in late February. Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei

acknowledged the exchange of messages with the US, but reiterated Tehran is seeking a definitive end to the war instead of a mere pause, according to *Shargh* newspaper. Cited by state TV, Baghaei said agreeing to a short-term detente without no guarantees that the cycle won’t be repeated is some-

thing “no rational person would do.” The fighting has left thousands dead, most of them in Iran and Lebanon, and brought vessel traffic through Hormuz — through which about a fifth of the world’s oil and liquefied natural gas exports normally flow — to a near standstill. Tehran continued striking energy targets in Persian Gulf neighbours, including Kuwait’s oil headquarters and a major petrochemicals plant in Abu Dhabi over the weekend. The UAE issued multiple alerts overnight, while Kuwait said its air defences intercepted missile and drone attacks. The Israel Defense Forces said Iran launched four waves of missiles since midnight, with emergency services saying they recovered

two bodies from a home struck earlier in Haifa. Majid Khademi, the head of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps’ Intelligence Organization, was killed in a US-Israeli strike, Iran’s semi-official *Fars* news agency said. Fifteen ships passed through the Strait of Hormuz with Iran’s permission over the course of 24 hours, *Fars* reported, adding that’s still about 90 per cent lower than before the start of the conflict. It didn’t elaborate on the ownership or destination of the vessels. Two tankers carrying Qatari liquefied natural gas appear to have abandoned an effort to exit the Persian Gulf through the Strait of Hormuz, delaying what would have been the first exports to buyers outside of the region since the war started.

Bitcoin reclaims \$70,000 on Iran ceasefire hopes

Bloomberg



Bitcoin jumped back above \$70,000 on Monday for the first time since March 25, as investors weighed reports that Iran was seeking a ceasefire in the ongoing war, even as US President Donald Trump escalated threats to attack civilian infrastructure. The original cryptocurrency rose more than 3.5 per cent, surpassing \$70,200 before paring some gains. It stood just under \$70,000 as of 10.35 am in London. Ether, the second-largest digital asset, rose as much as 5.1 per cent. Roughly \$273 million of bearish bets were unwound for cryptocurrencies in the last 24 hours, according to Coinglass data.

AGGRESSIVE THREATS

Trump on Sunday issued increasingly aggressive threats on social media, saying that the US would bring “Hell” to Iran if it didn’t reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a critical trade waterway that has been largely closed since the start of the war. Trump suggested that attacks on Iranian power plants could start as soon as Tuesday if the Strait isn’t opened. “Many Bitcoin shorts were initiated over the weekend, with the Middle East tensions rising again after Trump’s comments,” said Damien Loh, Chief Investment Officer at Ericsenz

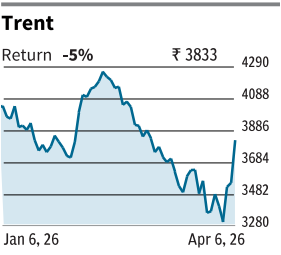
Capital. He pointed to holidays in Europe and Asia on Monday as adding to the volatility amid low liquidity. “Bitcoin is no longer a reliable proxy for overall risk sentiment, and when markets opened today, the switching of shorts into equity futures and the covering of some positions caused a squeeze higher in illiquid conditions.” Regional mediators have been pushing for a 45-day ceasefire as a last-ditch effort to bring the war to a close, Axios reported on Monday.

OIL PRICES

Oil prices pared gains earlier in the day, trading below \$108 a barrel. Gold was up about 0.5 per cent to more than \$4,700 an ounce. S&P 500 futures were up about 0.4 per cent, while similar contracts on Hyperliquid, where investors can trade tokenised contracts tracking other assets, gained 1.2 per cent. For weeks, Bitcoin has remained stuck roughly between \$65,000 and \$75,000.

Trent gains 8% on Q4 revenue jump

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Shares of Trent Ltd closed sharply higher on Monday after the Tata Group retailer reported a 20 per cent year-on-year rise in standalone revenue for the fourth quarter of FY26, lifting investor sentiment on an otherwise subdued market day. The stock closed at ₹3,833.60, up ₹283 or 7.97 per cent, on the NSE. It touched an intra-day high of ₹3,869.50 before settling near its peak, signalling sustained buying interest through the session. Traded volume for the day stood at 48.78 lakh shares, with total traded value crossing ₹1,838 crore — a notably heavy session. The volume-weighted average price for the day was ₹3,768.45. Total market capitalisation closed at approximately ₹1,36,322 crore. In a filing to the exchanges dated April 6, the company reported standalone revenue from operations of ₹4,937 crore for Q4FY26, up from ₹4,106 crore in Q4FY25. For the full year FY26, revenue rose 18 per cent to ₹19,701 crore from ₹16,668 crore in FY25. Revenue from merchandise sales, excluding other operating income, grew 21 per cent in the quarter and 19 per cent for the full year. On the expansion front, Trent’s total store count stood

at 1,286 as of March 31, comprising 300 Westside stores, 963 Zudio outlets (six of which are in the UAE) and 23 stores under other lifestyle concepts. During Q4FY26, the company added 22 Westside and 109 Zudio stores, with full-year net additions of 52 and 198, respectively. Despite today’s strong rally, the stock remains down 31.06 per cent over the past year and 10.76 per cent year-to-date. Its 52-week high stands at ₹6,261, hit on June 30, 2025.

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‘With govt policy support, MeitY is deepening involvement in semicon ecosystem’

The Hindu Bureau
Chennai



(from left) LV Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group; Panneerselvam Madanagopal, CEO, MeitY Startup Hub; Amitesh Kumar Sinha, Additional Secretary, MeitY, and CEO, India Semiconductor Mission; C Muthamizhchelvan, Vice-Chancellor, SRM Institute of Science and Technology; and B Govindarajan, CEO, Royal Enfield India, at the inaugural session of The Hindu DeepTech Summit 2026 in Chennai on Monday BUJOY GHOSH

“The Ministry of Electronics and IT is working on developing a complete ecosystem under the India Semiconductor Mission 2.0 to include materials, research and development, chemicals, gases, equipment manufacturing and skilling,” said Amitesh Kumar Sinha, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), and CEO, India Semiconductor Mission. Addressing the audience at the inaugural ceremony of The Hindu Deep Tech Summit 2026 by The Hindu Group, in association with the SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) here on Monday, he said, “The Ministry of Electronics and IT, in partnership with other Ministries, is taking steps in deep tech, backed by

the government on the policy front.” “Though India accounts for nearly 20 per cent of the world’s design engineers, we don’t have our own design companies, which is a challenge. The India Semiconductor Mission has a few verticals to address, and we started with design, manufacturing and packaging,”

Sinha said. “We are now deepening this involvement,” he added. LV Navaneeth, CEO, The Hindu Group, said deeptech is shaping economies, redefining industries and influencing the way people live, work and think. “From semiconductors and artificial intelligence to advanced materials and

space technologies, the next decade belongs to those who can engineer the future, not just imagine it,” he added. C Muthamizhchelvan, Vice-Chancellor, SRM Institute of Science and Technology, said that universities have been sending out talented graduates but not always solutions. “A deep tech summit like

this will eventually bridge the gap between intellectual potential on campuses and the expected impactful solutions for global challenges. The question we need to ask is: Are we really equipping our students how to build, what to think? Do we have sufficient infrastructure for laboratories for students and faculties to explore beyond what is prescribed in the curriculum and are we opening up to industries?” he wondered. Panneerselvam Madanagopal, CEO, MeitY Startup Hub, said that the need for industry-academia collaboration is extremely critical. “We need to look for fundamentally strong companies which are worthy of investment, solving real problems and driving change in the ecosystem,” he added.

ROLE OF DEEP TECH
B Govindarajan, CEO of Royal Enfield India, spoke

about the role of deeptech in the automobile industry. He said there is immense opportunity for the MSMEs, too, today, adding that about six crore MSMEs in India are performing well. “For the young minds who are into research and innovation, funding is not a challenge — both Indian industry and the government are ready to support ideas that solve real-world problems,” he said. **INDUSTRY PARTNER** The industry partner for the event is the Madras Management Association and the Knowledge partners include IHFC, Technology Innovation Hub of IIT Delhi, Ivy Club – Chennai, Satguru Catalysing Success, 2C Stem Steering Technology Management, BIRAC, Bio-Nest, NITI Aayog Atal Innovation Mission, DPIIT #startupindia, and the ecosystem partner is Startup Singam.

Enterprise Connect

HPCL ensures Robust Nationwide Fuel Supply; Delivers over 14 Lakhs LPG Cylinders on 2nd April 2026

14,10,000 LPG cylinders delivered across 55 bottling plants: 37,269 KL of Petrol & 75356 KL of Diesel sales, serving over 1.9 crore customers. 7,102 fuel tankers dispatched to ensure seamless retail supply. Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) continues to ensure uninterrupted supply of LPG and automotive fuels across the country. In the LPG segment, HPCL recorded deliveries of 14,10,000 cylinders from its 55 bottling plants, reaffirming its commitment to prompt and reliable service. Additionally, the Company supplied free trade LPG cylinders of 27,800 (5 kg) and 1,500 (2 kg). In the retail segment, HPCL achieved nozzle sales of 37,269 KL of Petrol and 75,356 KL of Diesel, reflecting stable supply trends. The Company served a widespread customer base of over 1.9 crore consumers during the day. To support seamless distribution, 7,102 tankers carrying Petrol and Diesel were dispatched to retail outlets from 80 supply locations. HPCL remains committed to maintaining uninterrupted and reliable supplies to its customers.



Shri Sandeep Bakhshi, MD & CEO, ICICI Bank. Graced IIM Jammu's 9th Annual Convocation 2026

The Indian Institute of Management Jammu hosted its 9th Annual Convocation on 2nd April 2026 marking a significant milestone in its journey of academic excellence, institutional growth, and nation-building. Shri Sandeep Bakhshi, Managing Director & CEO, ICICI Bank, graced the occasion as the Chief Guest and delivered the Convocation Address. Padma Shri Dr. Milind Kamble, Chairman, Board of Governors, IIM Jammu, delivered the welcome address, while Prof. B. S. Sahay, Director, IIM Jammu, presented the Director's Report, highlighting the Institute's key achievements and future roadmap. A key highlight of the occasion was the inauguration of the ICICI Bank Branch at the IIM Jammu Jagti Campus by Shri Sandeep Bakhshi, marking a significant step towards strengthening industry-institution collaboration and enhancing on-campus financial infrastructure. The academic procession formally marked the beginning of the Convocation ceremony, with the Chairman, BoG, declaring it open. Addressing the gathering, Shri Sandeep Bakhshi, Managing Director & CEO, ICICI Bank, described the present phase as India's "Goldilocks moment," characterized by strong economic growth, macroeconomic stability, and increasing global confidence. He highlighted the transformative role of India's digital public infrastructure, including Aadhaar and UPI, in advancing financial inclusion, enhancing efficiency, and fostering innovation across sectors. Reflecting on the evolution of the banking industry, he noted the shift from traditional models to technology-driven, data-centric systems built on the pillars of trust and sound governance. Padma Shri Dr. Milind P. Kamble, Chairman, Board of Governors, IIM Jammu, delivered a powerful message, India's rise is not just about becoming a large economy, but about building strong industries, advancing AI literacy, and aligning education with national priorities. Prof. B.S. Sahay, Director, Indian Institute of Management Jammu, warmly welcomed dignitaries, guests, and students, highlighting the Institute's continued excellence in placements. He expressed immense pride in students representing the Institute across prestigious organizations nationwide and noted its achievement of securing the 35th rank in the NIRF rankings.

'Next Leaders' category of the Indian Corporate Governance Scorecard Assessment 2025

Tata Power, one of India's largest integrated power companies has been positioned in the 'Next Leaders' category of the Indian Corporate Governance Scorecard Assessment 2025 undertaken by the Institutional Investor Advisory Services India Ltd (IIAS) for 2025. The inclusion is an outcome of an annual assessment of the S&P BSE 100 companies on the Indian Corporate Governance Scorecard framework, which has been jointly developed by the International Finance Corporation (IFC), BSE, and IIAS and is based on the G20/OECD principles of Corporate Governance and assesses company level governance practices across four equally weighted pillars: rights and equitable treatment of shareholders, sustainability and resilience, disclosures and transparency, and responsibilities of the board. This was the 10th edition of IIAS Indian Corporate Governance Scorecard, marking a decade of tracking the evolution of governance practices in corporate India. The 2025 assessment indicates a more mature governance landscape, with the focus shifting beyond formal compliance towards the quality of oversight, resilience, transparency, and long-term value creation. Institutional Investor Advisory Services India Limited (IIAS) is an advisory firm that provides capital markets with independent opinions, data, and analysis on governance and ESG, including voting recommendations and ESG ratings in India, through its wholly owned subsidiary IIAS Sustainability Solutions. The Indian Corporate Governance Scorecard, originally developed by IFC-BSE-IIAS, is built around the G20/OECD Principles of Corporate Governance. IIAS is a SEBI Research Analyst body.

Business Initiative

Strengthening Maritime Prowess: INS Taragiri Commissioned into the Indian Navy



In a landmark moment for India's maritime security, INS Taragiri, the indigenously built stealth frigate by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd (MDL), was formally commissioned into the Indian Navy at Visakhapatnam on Friday, April 3, 2026 by the hands of Hon'ble Raksha Mantri, Shri Rajnath Singh. Built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL), Mumbai, INS Taragiri is the third in the series of Project 17A, indicating another leap in India's indigenous warship design and construction. The basic design of the ship is carried out by the Indian Navy's in-house design organization viz. Warship Design Bureau. MDL has undertaken the detailed design & construction of the ship and Warship Overseeing Team (Mumbai) has overseen the construction. The ship, 149.02 m long, 17.8 M wide and drawing a displacement of 6400 Tons, is propelled by a combination of two (02) Gas Turbines and two (02) Main Diesel Engines (CODOG) which enables the ship to achieve a speed of over 28 knots at design displacement. INS Taragiri is equipped with State-of-the-art stealth features, advanced weapon systems, cutting-edge sensors and high-tech automation systems for streamlined operational efficiency. As part of the Project 17A class, the entry of INS Taragiri into the fleet will substantially enhance India's surveillance, operational reach, and maritime security across the Indian Ocean Region. There has been a considerable reduction in the build period in the series of ships being built under Project 17A at MDL. For this ship MDL achieved a reduction of 14% in build period when compared to First-of-Class. With the technical support of Indian Navy Team and Warship Overseeing Team (Mumbai), Taragiri was able to complete her Sea trials and Final Machinery Trials within three (3) months from Basin Trials which is an achievement for this class of vessels. As regards the combat readiness of the ship, the SRGM, AK 630, Kavach and IRL has achieved operational levels prior delivery with combined efforts of MDL, Indian Navy and OEMs. Further, successful Test Firing of Brahmos has been completed by Taragiri prior commissioning which is a first in P17A class. The commissioning of INS Taragiri embodies MDL's efforts towards the nation's commitment to self-reliance in defense manufacturing with 75% of indigenisation, aligning with the vision of Aatmanirbhar Bharat. It underscores the collaborative excellence of the Indian Navy, MDL and a wide ecosystem of indigenous industries including a wide network of MSMEs thus creating numerous employment opportunities both direct and indirect. This successful induction reaffirms India's growing stature as a global maritime power, capable of designing and building complex warships with indigenous expertise and innovation.

Jain Profession League – successfully conducted Cricket Tournament 2026



“The Jain Professionals League (JPL) successfully concluded its inspiring 2026 edition at the iconic Jain Gymkhana, bringing together Jain professionals for a memorable celebration of sport, unity, and community spirit. This premier cricket tournament witnessed enthusiastic participation from professionals across diverse fields, including Chartered Accountants, doctors, advocates, bankers, Company Secretaries, and corporate leaders. Designed as more than just a sporting event, the League fostered healthy competition, meaningful networking, and strong bonds within the Jain professional community. The tournament featured 20 competitive men's teams and 4 spirited women's teams, reflecting the League's growing scale and inclusivity. A special senior citizens' match was a heart-warming highlight, paying tribute to elders and their enduring passion for sportsmanship and active living. The event was blessed by the divine presence of Pujya Dhanjani Maharajasaheb and Pujya Akshajayi Maharajasaheb, whose ashirvachan inspired participants with messages of unity, discipline, and righteous living.

QUICKLY.

Gold holds nearly steady with focus on Gulf war



Gold prices were nearly steady on Monday, as market participants stayed cautious and awaited further signals on the evolving US-Iran situation. Spot gold was little changed at \$4,669.13 per ounce by 9:26 am ET (1326 GMT) after falling 1 per cent earlier in the session. US gold futures rose 0.3 per cent to \$4,694.20 per ounce. REUTERS

Palm oil slips on profit-booking

Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures edged lower on Monday as profit-taking pressured the market, though Thailand's crude palm oil export restrictions capped the decline. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange shed 27 ringgit to 4,812 ringgit (\$1,195.53) a tonne at the close. REUTERS

Crude oil falls on US-Iran receiving peace proposal



London: Crude oil fell more than \$2 in choppy trade on Monday, as investors awaited clarity on the status of US-Iran talks and remained wary about sustained supply losses due to shipping disruptions. Brent crude futures fell \$1.92 to \$107.11 a barrel at 1037 GMT. US West Texas Intermediate crude futures were trading down 1.82 per cent at \$109.50 per barrel. REUTERS

GITAM develops IoT-based system to help sericulture farmers

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

GITAM deemed-to-be-university, in association with the Department of Science and Technology (DST), has developed an IoT-based sericulture model that can help farmers improve their decision-making.

The system integrates in-field soil sensors, a micro-weather station and a cloud-based data layer that translates field inputs into actionable farm decisions, according to a statement.

Sericulture farmers rely on soil conditions, weather patterns and timing of intervention to sustain yield and quality. Most decisions at the farm level are still based on observation rather than real-time data. This affects consistency, input efficiency and income stability, and reflects a broader challenge in adopting technology at the last

Govt may curb sugar exports to allow higher ethanol blending with petrol

MOUNTING DUES. Centre concerned about ₹16,918 crore of sugarcane dues that have piled up till March-end

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Amid the Indian ethanol industry lobbying for blending beyond 20 per cent, a global agency has said that any hike from the E20 level will require India to ban sugar exports, potentially helping the government to control domestic prices when global rates are predicted to jump in April-June quarter.

“India, having achieved E20, appears increasingly likely to pursue a further expansion of its ethanol mandate. While India has capacity for further ethanol expansion, realising it will require the country to further restrict sugar exports, weighing on global supply and underpinning prices at the margin,” BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions, said in a report, ‘Outlook for sugar prices’.

On Monday at the daily



EXPORT SHORTFALL. In 2024-25, the country exported 9 lt of sugar against the 10 lt permitted by the government. REUTERS

media briefing on the West Asia crisis, when asked about any plan to raise ethanol blending with petrol (EBP) beyond 20 per cent, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Petroleum Ministry, declined to comment. She just said: “As of now, it stands at 20 per cent.”

India had faced a sugar shortage in the 2022-23 season. As a result, exports were restricted and despite a bumper output in 2023-24, no shipments were permitted.

In 2024-25, the country

exported 9 lakh tonnes (lt) against the permitted 10 lt whereas in the current season (October-September), the government allowed 15.9 lt so far of which over 3.7 lt have been exported.

PENDING ARREARS

Industry sources said the government is concerned about the ₹16,918 crore of sugarcane dues (to be paid to farmers by the mills) piled up till the end of March in the current crushing season that started from October 1, 2025.

“Though 84 per cent of the ₹1.07 lakh crore dues have been cleared by the mills, the arrear in terms of the absolute number is still a concern, when there is scope for getting more ethanol from sugar factories,” an industry official said.

He said oil marketing companies (OMCs) had placed orders for only 288.51 crore litres of ethanol in cycle 1 from sugar factories, whereas they have a combined capacity to produce nearly 1,000 crore litres annually. Of the order received, 46 per cent had been supplied until March 15, sources said. In comparison, grain-based units have supplied 31 per cent of the 759.75 crore litres worth of supply orders received.

According to the BMI report, the global sugar price having averaged US cent 14.6/lb (of 0.454 kg) in the first quarter of CY2026 (January-March), there may

be a gradual recovery, with quarterly averages projected at US¢16.2/lb in Q2 (April-June), US¢16.6/lb in Q3 (July-September) and US¢17.2/lb in Q4 (October-December). The annual average for CY2026 is seen at US cent 16.2/lb.

The report also expressed concern over the likely impact of El Nino comparing it with 2023 (when monsoon rainfall was 6 per cent deficient), resulting in lower sugar production in the 2024-25 season. Sugar production in the 2024-25 season dipped to 261 lt from 320 lt in 2023-24.

“The historical evidence for this transmission mechanism is well established; the 2023-24 El Niño coincided with an estimated 9 per cent decline in Indian sugarcane production and a projected 15 per cent reduction in Thai output, driving global sugar prices to their highest level since 2011,” BMI said.

LPG shortage halts Sterling Agro’s bulk sales

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad



Sterling Agro Industries Ltd, which markets dairy products under the ‘Nova’ brand, has not sold a single bulk pack of ghee or milk powder in the last 20 days, signalling sharp demand disruption in the dairy sector amid the ongoing West Asia conflict and LPG shortage.

“We have not sold a single 15 kg tin of ghee or 25 kg skimmed milk powder pack in the last 20 days,” Ravin Saluja, Director at the company told *businessline*.

Bulk packs, sold in large formats to food service and confectionery players, account for nearly 50 per cent of sales for manufacturers like Sterling Agro, which reported ₹2,190 crore revenue in FY25. The development points to a broader demand shock in the industry’s bulk segment, which caters primarily to institutional buyers such as caterers, hotels and sweet shops.

“Because of this war, the milk industry is facing a major challenge. It is not just exports — there is an LPG shortage. This has led to a drop in demand from caterers, canteens, hotels and sweet shops,” Saluja said.

Sterling Agro owns and operates three factories with a daily milk handling capacity of 2.6 million litres. Products are marketed under the brand names of ‘Nova’ and ‘A-One’.

TWIN HIT

Sterling Agro is a preferred supplier for bulk customers, which include large institutions and well-known multinational corporations. It derives about ₹60 crore from international markets.

Industry players said that the domestic slowdown comes alongside disruptions in exports due to the conflict involving Iran, which has impacted shipping routes and logistics.

The domestic slowdown comes alongside disruptions in exports due to the conflict involving Iran, which has impacted shipping routes and logistics

Shipments to key markets, such as Saudi Arabia and the Gulf region, have slowed, with shipping lines imposing war risk surcharges and vessel availability tightening.

“The shipping lines have added a war surcharge of \$2,000 per shipment, plus the ships are not easily available,” Saluja said.

In some cases, consignments have been stranded mid-route, forcing companies to offload cargo at transit ports and rework sales, adding to costs. Recently, 100 tonnes of anhydrous milk fat, which was meant to be shipped to Russia, got stranded at a port in the UAE, and Sterling Agro was forced to sell the product in the West Asia market.

“The prices of milk products have increased in West Asia but we are not able to take advantage as materials are not being shipped to the West Asia markets. Even in the case of the stranded AMF cargo, we did not make any profit as the cost of changing the documents, testing of materials, cost of warehousing, etc. impacted our bottomline,” he added.

Packaging costs have also risen sharply due to a shortage of raw materials and industrial gas used in manufacturing export barrels.

Coffee exports hit a record high of \$2.13 b in FY26

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

Coffee exports registered 17 per cent growth to a record \$2.136 billion for FY26 on higher prices and a modest increase in volume. In the previous year, shipments were to the tune of \$1.82 billion.

As per the latest data released by the Coffee Board, export volumes increased by 4.65 per cent to cross 4.07 lakh tonnes (lt) during FY26; the figure was over 3.88 lt in 2024-25. In rupee terms, exports grew 22.47 per cent to ₹18,887 crore over ₹15,421

crore. The per unit value realised by exporters was up 17 per cent at ₹4,64,041 per tonne against ₹3,96,525.

Ramesh Rajah, President, Coffee Exporters Association, said shipments witnessed a record high in value and volume during 2025-26, breaking earlier records. “A 5 per cent growth in volumes is a commendable performance on a higher base,” Rajah said, adding that the growth in shipments was possible due to a higher crop.

WAR IMPACT

Coffee output during 2024-25 (October-September crop year) was 3.63 lt, comprising

Brewing gains

Financial year	Volume (tonnes)	Value (\$ million)
2025-26	4,07,014	2,136
2024-25	3,89,967	1,820
2023-24	3,83,965	1,286
2022-23	3,96,346	1,146

Source: Coffee Board

1.05 lt of arabica and 2.57 lt of robusta.

Shipments to West Asia have slowed down and are stranded at various safe ports due to disruption in logistics on account of the war in the region. “It is too early to quantify or predict the impact on exports to West Asia

in the current financial year,” he said.

However, shipments to Europe, the main market for Indian coffees, are going through the Cape of Good Hope. “We expect the shipments to Europe to pick up,” Rajah said.

Kurma Rao M, CEO and Secretary, Coffee Board, said the initiatives taken by the government towards ease of doing business had helped boost the shipments. Besides, the demand for value-added coffees also contributed to the growth, he said.

Italy, Germany, the Russian Federation, Belgium and Turkey continue to be

Natural gas: Go long at ₹268, stop-loss at ₹248

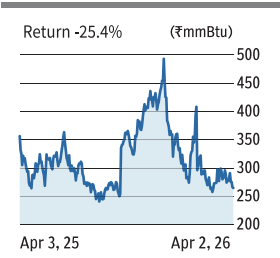
Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Natural gas futures, which lost nearly 9 per cent last week, have begun the current one on a muted note. The April contract is now trading at ₹268 (per mmBtu).

COMMODITY CALL.

Although the contract dropped last week, it is sustaining above the support at ₹255. Immediate support below ₹255 is at ₹250. Therefore, the price band of ₹250-₹255 is a support band. Notably, the price of the futures has not decisively slipped below this level in seven months.

A rebound on the back of this, which is likely to occur, could lift the futures to the resistance region between ₹300 and ₹310. A breakout of the latter could take the con-



tract further higher to ₹325.

On the other hand, if the contract breaches the support at ₹250, it could quickly fall to ₹235. A breakdown below ₹235 could turn the medium-term outlook bearish, potentially dragging the contract to ₹200 or lower. That said, as the support at ₹250 remains valid at the moment, the chances for a recovery are high.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy April futures at ₹268. Target and stop-loss can be ₹300 and ₹248, respectively. After initiating the trade, if the contract rises to ₹290, revise the stop-loss to ₹285.

War hits activated carbon exports as costs surge amid shipping woes

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi



Activated carbon exports have been impacted by the ongoing West Asia crisis due to the unavailability of shipping services to certain sectors, higher ocean freight and war risk surcharge.

Joshy Joseph, Director of IndCarb, the Palakkad-based manufacturer and exporter of activated carbon, told *businessline* that the current crisis in the Gulf region is more severe than the US tariff issue; it has entirely blocked cargo movement to countries, such as Sudan and Egypt, where activated carbon is in high demand, thanks to the presence of gold mines.

Activated carbon is used in gold extraction, and purification of water and air. Sudan is reported to be the second highest gold producer in the African region after Ghana.

However, the blockade of the Red Sea has disrupted cargo movement to the country, hitting activated carbon manufacturers badly, he said. The other option of diverting cargo via the Cape of Good Hope is time-consuming and costly, he said.

LACK OF VESSELS

Besides, the war risk premium of \$3,000 per 40 ft container, imposed by shipping lines for new cargo as well as already shipped consignments, has not gone

down well with manufacturers, who have opposed the war risk surcharge on consignments that are already onboard, on which they have paid the freight charge up to their respective destinations.

The non-availability of vessels to Russia is also posing a problem, forcing exporters to take containers to Nhava Sheva Port for shipment. This forced them to incur an additional cost of ₹1.5 lakh for dispatching containers to the Nhava Sheva port, he said.

The high price of coconut shells is also a concern for the sector.

The raw material price has risen to more than ₹90,000 per tonne, compared to ₹45,000 in FY25.

The US is a major importer of activated carbon, with exports from India reported to be around ₹4,000 crore in FY26 against ₹2,800 crore in FY25, he said.

Crystal Crop Protection launches fodder seed products for kharif 2026

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Crystal Crop Protection Ltd, an integrated agri-input company, will offer a comprehensive range of fodder seed products to serve diverse agro-climatic needs in kharif 2026. These include ‘SX17’, ‘SX17 Super’, ‘SX21’ and ‘Star’.

A statement said ‘SX17’ is a high-yielding sorghum-Sudan hybrid with robust stem, medium maturity and good re-growth, while ‘SX17 Super’ is an enhanced version of ‘SX17’ with improved drought tolerance and higher biomass per cut.

As per the statement, ‘SX21’ is a late-maturing, high-biomass variety ideal for single-cut large volume harvests, and ‘Star’ is an

early-maturing dual-purpose sorghum, used as both green fodder and grain fodder.

Crystal Crop’s ‘2026 Fodder Initiative’ is anchored across Haryana, Punjab, western Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan. These regions are dominated by the cultivation of crops such as sorghum (jowar), maize, bajra, be-seem and lucerne.

PURPOSE-ENGINEERED The company’s single-cut green fodder hybrid — ‘Dairy Green’ — has been purpose-engineered to address the nutritional requirements of high-yielding dairy cattle.

Developed through advanced plant breeding, ‘Dairy Green’ delivers consistently high biomass yield, superior crude protein content and excellent palatability, making it the preferred

choice for dairy farmers, it said.

Satyender Singh, Chief Executive Officer (Seeds), Crystal Crop Protection, said India’s livestock sector is at an inflection point. The challenge is no longer just about milk productivity. It begins at the farm gate with the quality and availability of green fodder.

“At Crystal, we have invested over a decade in developing seed solutions that directly address this gap. ‘Dairy Green’ represents our finest effort, a seed that consistently delivers more nutrition per acre, enabling dairy farmers to achieve higher milk yields while reducing their feed cost burden. Our expanded portfolio for kharif 2026 ensures that India’s farmers have the right tools for every condition,” he said.

Thermal coal poised to gain more if West Asia conflict prolongs

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Thermal coal prices, which have gained over 10 per cent in the past month and over 35 per cent this year as the Iran war forces some of the countries to shift from LNG, will likely gain if the Iran war continues for a longer period.

Analysts said the energy market faces more pressure as prices of LNG soar and Asian countries counter problems due to rising prices and short supplies. The Newcastle coal futures contract for April has surged to \$142.50 a tonne on the Inter-Continental Exchange currently.

Research agency BMI, a unit of Fitch Solutions, said that since the Iran war began, thermal coal prices at Newcastle port in Australia had climbed 18 per cent. Car-

goes traded as high as \$145/tonne as of March 20, the highest since November 2024. Time-spreads between first and six-month contracts were also widening from \$5/tonne to \$8/tonne, signalling strong demand for high-grade tonnage.

PRICE FORECAST

Similarly, prices for API2 coal delivered to European ports have increased 13 per cent to \$121/tonne, while API4 coal shipped from Richards Bay port in South Africa has gained 10 per cent to \$110/tonne. Among the lower grade cargoes, Indonesian 4,200 kcal/kg coal from East Kalimantan has gained 12 per cent since the war began, trading at \$57/tonne.

“The conflict between the United States and Iran, which began on February 28, has disrupted shipping via the Strait of Hormuz, a vital waterway responsible for 20



PRICE HIKE. Research agency BMI said since the Iran war began, thermal coal prices at Newcastle port in Australia had climbed 18 per cent

per cent of global LNG supply. We expect higher natural gas prices to encourage fuel switching in key Asian markets, with thermal coal being the biggest beneficiary due to its ability to deliver relatively cheap baseload power,” said BMI.

South Asian countries face particular exposure as Qatari LNG accounts for 60 per

cent of the region’s supply mix, while North-East Asia relies on Qatar for about 15 per cent of its LNG supply, said Morgan Stanley.

“We are increasing our 2026 price forecast for Newcastle thermal coal to \$115/tonne from \$100 previously,” said BMI.

According to analysts at Jefferies, thermal coal could

garner market share from natural gas in seaborne markets if LNG prices surge due to the war. They expect price-sensitive nations in Asia to shift to coal.

Australia’s Westpac Bank said four weeks of conflict had forced a harder reckoning for global markets. “US-Iran de-escalation looks increasingly distant, and markets are increasingly pricing in duration, not resolution,” it said, adding coal shipments could increase from Down Under.

Morgan Stanley estimated that Japan, Korea and Taiwan could need an additional 1.5-2 million tonnes of thermal coal a month if the disruption in LNG exports continues. This would be an 8-10 per cent rise in demand.

BMI said the damage inflicted on Qatari gas facilities by Iran will lead to prolonged disruption to LNG supply even after the conflict ends.

